

NOTES ON Gravity and Cosmology

version 1.0

Giacomo Pannocchia

a.y. 2025-2026

For those who come after

PREFACE

In a sense, you might say I'm getting quite fond of writing these kind of notes.

Not long ago, it occurred to me how cool it is when someone unexpectedly releases a very detailed and all-comprehensive version of their notes, especially when dealing with a course that has a handful of topics often interacting together in unpredictable, yet fascinating, ways.

These notes will be mainly based on *my* own notes of the lectures by Professor Omar Zanusso for the DG, Hamiltonian, and BHs parts, and on the notes of the lectures by Professors Giovanni Marozzi and Daniele Gaggero for the Cosmology part.

These notes refer to the lectures of the academic year 2025-2026, so future versions of these lectures might differ slightly.

At any rate, since I take little to no pride in my messy notes, I'll be often using some of the references you can find on the course catalogue page or that have been cited during class. Either way, I'll do my best keeping track of them all in the bibliography of this humble collection.

You can report errors (whatever their nature might be) and suggestions for additions at g.pannocchia3@studenti.unipi.it or through whatever convoluted way (conventional or not) you prefer¹.

You can find all the notes I've redacted [here](#).

Without further ado, we'd better not lose much more time on a preface and get started with it.

There was Eru, the One, who in Arda is called Ilúvatar; and he made first the Ainur [...] But for a long while they sang only each alone, or but few together, while the rest hearkened; for each comprehended only that part of the mind of Ilúvatar from which he came, and in the understanding of their brethren they grew but slowly. Yet ever as they listened they came to deeper understanding, and increased in unison and harmony.

*Ainulindalë, "The music of the Ainur",
Silmarillion, J. R. R. Tolkien*

¹ I'd like, however, not to see my house stormed by homing pigeons.

CONTENTS

1	Basis of Differential Geometry	1
2	Hamiltonian Approach	3
3	Black Holes	5
4	Cosmology	7
4.1	Maximally Symmetric Universes	9
4.1.1	Isometries and Killing Vectors	9
4.1.2	The Bare Minimum to Begin	10
4.2	Friedmann-Robertson-Walker Metrics	14
4.2.1	Geodesics	15
4.2.2	A short detour on redshift	17
4.2.3	Hubble-Le Maître's Law	19
4.3	The road to Friedmann's Equations	19
4.3.1	Energy-Momentum Tensor and Its Conservation	20
4.3.2	Ricci Tensor in a FLRW Metric	21
4.3.3	Friedmann's Equation	22
4.3.4	Einstein Universe	24
4.3.5	Critical Density	26
4.4	Dynamic Age of the Universe	29
4.5	Inflation	30
5	Thermal History of the Universe	31
5.0.1	Statistical Properties	31
5.0.2	Effective Number of Relativistic Species	33
5.0.3	Conservation of Entropy	34
5.1	Neutrino Decoupling	36
5.2	Electron-Positron Annihilation	37
5.3	Photon Recombination and Decoupling	39
5.3.1	Hydrogen recombination	39
5.3.2	Photon Decoupling	40
5.4	Dark Matter	41
5.4.1	Galaxy Clusters	43
5.4.2	WIMPS	45
5.5	Big Bang Nucleosynthesis	48
I	Appendix	
6	Appendix	51
	Bibliography	59

1

BASIS OF DIFFERENTIAL GEOMETRY

Coming soon [3].

2 | HAMILTONIAN APPROACH

Coming soon.

3 | BLACK HOLES

Coming soon.

4

COSMOLOGY

PRE-RELATIVISTIC COSMOLOGY AND ITS PROBLEMS

Long before GR as we know it today was a thing, Cosmology was already an open field of study. Of course, in this first age of Cosmology, studies were based on Newtonian mechanics and the Newtonian theory of gravity.

Newtonian Cosmology assumed an infinite, homogeneous, and static Universe, which was also eternal and responded to Euclidean geometry. Not surprisingly, under this set of un-reasonable hypothesis¹, problems began to sprout overnight.

Consider for example the so called **Olber's paradox** (1826). Under the assumptions of Newtonian Cosmology, Olber's paradox would implicate an always-bright sky, while we have empirical evidence it isn't. In fact, the total luminosity of a set of stars with solar luminosity $L_{\odot}$ within a sphere of radius R

$$\phi_s = \int_0^R \frac{L_{\odot}}{4\pi r^2} n_s 4\pi r^2 dr$$

will tend to infinity once $R \rightarrow \infty$. That is because, under the hypothesis of homogeneity, the surface density of stars n_s cannot depend on the spatial coordinates.

Olber will then try to solve his own paradox, claiming it to be solved by dust in the ISM (read: Interstellar Medium). But, if you think about it, it really doesn't solve anything: Sooner or later, the dust itself will get into thermodynamical equilibrium with the radiation, and at that point dust will begin to emit on its own.

A second solution was given in 1872 from Zolbnev, who assumed that the Universe is *closed* with a *positive curvature*. The Universe would then be finite, and the assumption of homogeneity wouldn't let the integral above diverge.

However, solved a problem, there's always another one² peeking around the corner. In this particular case it's the problem of gravitational stability. In fact, it's evident that local instabilities in the gravitational potential must have occurred at some point in time through fluctuations of density, leading to collapses and star formation epochs. As I said, the problem is mainly local, and instabilities are generally balanced on the larger scales.

Bentley then showed that perturbations on spatial scale r have, under the assumption of homogeneity, an associated potential $\propto r^2$ and an associated acceleration $\propto r$, which leads to unstable equilibrium.

This problem is however partially mitigated by Seelinger (1895), who assumes gravity to be *shielded* on the large scales

$$\phi = G \int \frac{\rho}{r} d^3x \rightarrow \phi = G \int \frac{\rho}{r} e^{-\lambda r} d^3x$$

¹ The only reasonable assumption was for the Universe to be homogeneous and, only at times, static. The rest of the hypothesis were arguable at best.

² "Always two there are."

where the exponential term is an absorption/shielding factor. This correction will thus bring about a modification of Poisson's equation

$$\nabla^2\phi = 4\pi G\rho \rightarrow \nabla^2\phi - \lambda\phi = 4\pi G\rho$$

Much expectedly, quite a lot changed since 1917, when relativistic cosmology was officially born [5]. Einstein's GR was based on three main principles:

1. (Weak) Equivalence Principle: Inertial acceleration and gravitational acceleration are proportional to each other. Hence all free-falling systems are locally equivalent to an inertial system;
2. General Covariance Principle: When written in covariant form, the laws of Physics are the same in all reference frame;
3. Mach's Principle³ The momentum of all bodies is determined by all the masses in the Universe. Alternatively, the only things with physical sense are those that are measurable.

Only a year prior to Einstein's 1917 article, Schwarzschild had already found a solution to Einstein's celebrated equation under the assumption of a single spherical body in an otherwise empty space. Such solution, that is nowadays known as Schwarzschild's metric, has to the perk to come down to the standard spacetime Minkowski's metric at infinite distance from the object. This, of course, felt like a big problem for Mach's philosophical principle.

Einstein, perhaps conditioned from the beliefs of his time, twisted his theory so to produce a closed, static Universe. To do so, he only had to add a single term to his equation, the Cosmological Constant

$$G_{\mu\nu} - \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu} \quad (1)$$

which is actually perfectly valid, even from a theoretical point of view⁴. That said, the interpretation of the Λ term was somewhat...elusive.

In 1918, Erwin Schrödinger suggested that the Cosmological Constant was equivalent to the energy-momentum tensor of a fluid with negative pressure, and could thus be included in the right-hand side term of the equation.

But, as you perhaps know, even Einstein was prone to errors like any other human being. In 1917, Vesto Slipher observed a discrepancy in the observed emission lines of some galaxies (with respect to the expected frequencies). He, however, failed to correlate such discrepancy to the distance of the aforementioned galaxies.

It was only when Hubble measured their distance [6] through the Cepheid-variables method that cosmologists started to realize that the Universe was expanding rather than being static; the expansion law of the Universe still carries Hubble's name, who was the first to suggest such correlation.

Another viable model to describe the Universe is the so-called "Einstein-De Sitter" Universe. This model essentially assumes the Universe to be akin to a non-relativistic fluid for the sake of computing the resulting metric and

³ This one is a bit "philosophical", but it's interesting to at least mention it.

⁴ I assume the four readers of these notes to be at least familiar with the terms and symbols used. If not, I suggest reading [3] or any graduate/postgraduate textbook about GR.

the properties stemming from it. This model was however abandoned because it produced errors in the estimation of the age of the Universe⁵.

Thermodynamical Considerations on the Big Bang

The Laws of Thermodynamics speak rather clearly: Energy is (globally) conserved, and Entropy either remains constant or grows. But, if entropy is not growing, the system (i.e. the Universe) doesn't evolve and will meet its end in a rather ominous-sounding way: Thermal Death.

If, on the other hand, entropy is allowed to grow, then it is possible for the system to switch to more probable microscopical configurations. So, starting from a low-entropy, extremely ordered state, the Universe would then evolve through thermodynamical means into the messy Universe we see today.

4.1 MAXIMALLY SYMMETRIC UNIVERSES

Note: Parts of this section will be eventually removed and integrated into Chapter 1 when I'll have it sorted out. So, for the moment, you'll have to take it at face value, which, admittedly, feels a tad random.

4.1.1 Isometries and Killing Vectors

Consider a metric $g_{\mu\nu}$ and a given map of coordinates x_μ (which roughly translates into choosing a given reference frame). The metric will thus transform according to the standard tensor transformation rule

$$g'_{\mu\nu}(x') = \frac{\partial x^\rho}{\partial x'^\mu} \frac{\partial x^\sigma}{\partial x'^\nu} g_{\rho\sigma}(x) \quad (2)$$

We'll say that a particular transformation $x \rightarrow x'$ is an *isometry* if

$$g'_{\rho\sigma}(y) = g_{\rho\sigma}(y) \quad (3)$$

If we consider an infinitesimal transformation of the likes

$$x'^\mu = x^\mu + \epsilon \xi^\mu \quad (4)$$

with $|\epsilon| \ll 1$, we can substitute directly into the transformation equation for the metric. Under the request of the transformation being an isometry, we'll obtain

$$\partial_\rho \xi^\mu g_{\mu\sigma} \partial_\sigma \xi^\nu g_{\rho\nu} + \xi^\mu \partial_\mu g_{\rho\sigma} = 0 \quad (5)$$

We can then introduce Christoffel's symbols to cast the equation in an equivalent form

$$\partial_\rho \xi_\sigma + \partial_\sigma \xi_\rho - 2\xi_\mu \Gamma^\mu_{\rho\sigma} = 0 \quad (6)$$

The vector ξ^μ will be a *Killing vector* if it satisfies Killing's equation

$$\nabla_\rho \xi_\sigma + \nabla_\sigma \xi_\rho = 0 \quad (7)$$

⁵ It turned out that some white dwarves, low mass stars that had reached the end of their evolution cycle, would be older than the Universe. I hope you'll agree with me that it would be at least a bit odd.

If a given spacetime manifold has n spatial dimensions, then the space can have *at most* $n(n + 1)/2$ Killing vectors. Such space is called *maximally symmetric*.

4.1.2 The Bare Minimum to Begin

Contemporary cosmological models are based on the idea the the Universe is pretty much the same everywhere, a stance sometimes known as the *Copernican Principle* or *Cosmological principle*. If we take it at face value, such a claim seems crazy, if at all logical: There's little resemblance, say, between the center of the Sun (which is kinda hot) and the desolate cold of the ISM. The Cosmological Principle starts to make a little more sense if we take it to apply only on the very largest scales, where local variations in density are averaged over and magically disappear.

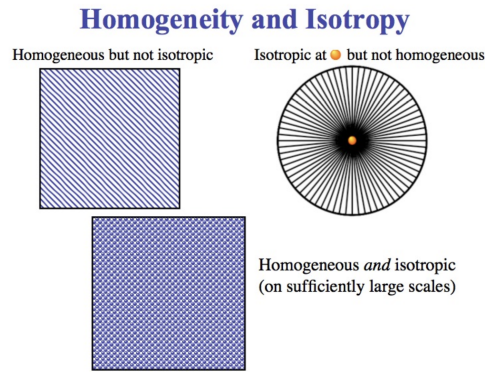


Figure 1: The Cosmological Principle automatically translates in two very specific requests: Homogeneity and Isotropy.

The Cosmological principle is related to two more mathematically precise properties that we can request our space-time manifold to have: *Isotropy* and *Homogeneity*, which are given a pictorial representation in Fig.1.

Homogeneity

Consider a family of hypersurfaces defined by some parameter t which allows us to foliate the manifold. Given any two points p and q in a manifold M , there is an isometry that takes p into q . See [3].

The assumption of Homogeneity essentially requires that the metric is the same throughout the manifold.

Isotropy

A manifold M is isotropic around a point p if, for any two vectors V and W in the tangent space of M to the point p $T_p M$, there is an isometry (symmetry) of M such that the *pushforward* of W under the isometry is parallel with V (not pushed forward). See [3].

Isotropy, instead, states that space looks exactly the same around a given point, no matter in what direction you're looking.

It turns out that a manifold that is simultaneously homogeneous and isotropic is also maximally symmetric! In fact the transformations associated to isotropy are the rotations

$$x'^{\mu} = R^{\mu}_{\nu} x^{\nu} \quad (8)$$

which generate $n(n-1)/2$ Killing vectors. On the other hand, the transformations associated to homogeneity are the translations

$$x'^{\mu} = x^{\mu} + \zeta^{\mu} \quad (9)$$

which generate n Killing vectors. The total number of Killing vector is, as expected, exactly $n(n+1)/2$. A spacetime which has a maximally symmetric spatial section must have a special metric that reflects such properties. Let's start from a general metric

$$ds^2 = g_{\mu\nu} dx^{\mu} dx^{\nu} \quad (10)$$

Clearly, off-diagonal terms like g_{0i} must be vanishing $g_{0i} = 0$, or the request of an isotropic manifold wouldn't be met. This already leaves us with a metric with the following expression

$$ds^2 = -(u_{\mu} dx^{\mu})^2 + g_{ij}(t) dx^i dx^j \quad (11)$$

where the first term of the right-hand side represents the projection of the displacement along the tangent vector u^{μ} , which is, by virtue of its own definition, perpendicular to the spatial hypersurfaces.

Let's focus on the spatial metric $g_{ij}(t)$. Thanks to isotropy, the temporal dependence of the metric has to factor out, so that

$$g_{ij}(t) = a^2(t) \tilde{g}_{ij} \quad (12)$$

where we've introduced the *scale factor* $a(t)$.

Taking $u_{\mu} = (1, 0, 0, 0)$, our metric turns out to be

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t) \tilde{g}_{ij} dx^i dx^j \quad (13)$$

Let's now consider a n -dimensional geometry which we embed into a $n+1$ dimensional space.

3-Dimensional Space

So let's, for example, write down the metric for a 2-dimensional sphere embedded in a 3-dimensional space. The 3-dimensional Euclidean metric is

$$dl^2 = dx_1^2 + dx_2^2 + dx_3^2 \quad (14)$$

where we can define the radius of a given sphere a as

$$a^2 = x_1^2 + x_2^2 + x_3^2 \quad (15)$$

which we can implicitly differentiate to obtain an expression for, say, dx_3 which we'll plug into (14)

$$dx_3 = -\frac{x_1 dx_1 + x_2 dx_2}{\pm(a^2 - x_1^2 - x_2^2)^{1/2}} \quad (16)$$

so that the line element induced on the 2-sphere is

$$dl^2 = dx_1^2 + dx_2^2 + \frac{(x_1 dx_1 + x_2 dx_2)^2}{a^2 - x_1^2 - x_2^2} \quad (17)$$

We can define a vector $\vec{x} = (x_1, x_2)$, so that the line element can be expressed in a more compact fashion

$$dl^2 = d\vec{x}^2 + \frac{(\vec{x} \cdot d\vec{x})^2}{a^2 - \vec{x}^2} \quad (18)$$

Flat Space

The case of a flat space with vanishing curvature can be dealt with starting from the metric induced on the sphere, simply imposing $a \rightarrow \infty$. Not surprisingly, the resulting metric will be

$$dl^2 = d\vec{x}^2$$

Similarly, we can also calculate the induced metric on a 2-dimension hyperbola

$$a^2 = x_1^2 + x_2^2 - x_3^2 \quad (19)$$

The passages are essentially identical to those for the sphere, and the resulting metric is

$$dl^2 = d\vec{x}^2 - \frac{(\vec{x} \cdot d\vec{x})^2}{a^2 + \vec{x}^2} \quad (20)$$

For our future discussions it will be really useful to define a scaled-down x vector $\tilde{x} = \vec{x}/a$, so that the expression for the line element can be conveniently expressed as

$$dl^2 = a^2 \left(d\tilde{x}^2 + k \frac{(\tilde{x} \cdot d\tilde{x})^2}{1 - k\tilde{x}^2} \right) \quad (21)$$

where we've introduced the parameter $k = 0, \pm 1$, which defines the topological properties of the space we're considering.

Sometimes (read: almost always) it is useful to express the metric through the polar coordinates of the 2-dimensional sphere. With such purpose in mind, we're defining x_3 as the "height" of a certain circular section, r' the radius of such section, and θ the azimuthal angle with respect to axis parallel to x_1 . In formulas

$$\begin{aligned} x_3^2 &= a^2 - r'^2 \\ x_1 &= r' \cos \theta \\ x_2 &= r' \sin \theta \end{aligned}$$

With this new set of coordinates, the line element of the 2-dimensional sphere becomes

$$dl^2 = dr'^2 + r'^2 d\theta^2 + \frac{(r' dr')^2}{a^2 - r'^2} = a^2 \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - r^2} + r^2 d\theta^2 \right) \quad (22)$$

where we've also introduced the adimensional radius $r = r'/a$, which lives in the interval $r \in [0, 1]$. We can repeat the calculations for the hyperbola

and the flat space in a similar fashion. The final result for the three scenarios we've considered can be once again expressed in a single expression thanks to the k parameter

$$dl^2 = a^2 \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\theta^2 \right) \quad (23)$$

4-Dimensional Space

Perhaps it might have occurred to you that we do not, in fact, live in a 3-dimensional space, but rather in a 4-dimensional one with 3-dimensional spatial sections. The purpose of this section is essentially to replicate the calculations we've already went through for the 3-dimensional space but with one more additional dimension to address.

For this purpose, it comes somewhat in handy recalling (21), which allows us to immediately find the expression for the line element induced on a 3-dimensional surface embedded in a 4-dimensional space. All we have to do is replacing the metric of the 1-sphere S_1 ($d\theta^2$), with that of the 2-sphere S_2 , the solid angle $d\Omega_{(2)}^2$

$$dl^2 = a^2 \left(d\tilde{x}^2 + k \frac{(\tilde{x} \cdot d\tilde{x})^2}{1 - k\tilde{x}^2} \right) = a^2 \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\Omega_{(2)}^2 \right) \quad (24)$$

For example, the metric induced on the sphere ($k = 1$) can be obtained defining the spherical coordinates (χ, θ, ϕ) and a radial distance a , so that

$$x_1^2 + x_2^2 + x_3^2 + x_4^2 = a^2 \quad (25)$$

and the line element is

$$dl^2 = dx_1^2 + dx_2^2 + dx_3^2 + dx_4^2 \quad (26)$$

Performing the due substitutions you'd obtain

$$dl^2 = a^2 (d\chi^2 + \sin^2 \chi d\Omega_{(2)}^2) \quad (27)$$

The metric induced on the hyperboloid is obtained replacing $\sin \chi$ with $\sinh \chi$. Note that the new radial coordinate χ is adimensional, is in the range $[0, \pi]$, and is defined through

$$d\chi = \frac{dr}{\sqrt{1 - kr^2}} \quad (28)$$

In the hyperboloid case, the radial coordinate χ will now be in the range $[0, \infty)$, and the associated Cartesian coordinates are

$$\begin{aligned} x_1 &= a \sinh \chi \sin \theta \cos \phi \\ x_2 &= a \sinh \chi \sin \theta \sin \phi \\ x_3 &= a \sin \chi \cos \theta \\ x_4 &= a \cos \chi \end{aligned}$$

We can go through several boring substitutions to find the induced line element

$$dl^2 = a^2 (d\chi^2 + \sinh^2 \chi d\Omega_{(2)}^2) \quad (29)$$

and the compact expression for the three surfaces we're considering is

$$\boxed{dl^2 = a^2 \left(d\chi^2 + \frac{1}{k} \sin^2(\sqrt{k}\chi) d\Omega_{(2)}^2 \right)} \quad k = 0, \pm 1 \quad (30)$$

where we've made use of the fact that the line element can be conveniently expressed as

$$dl^2 = a^2 (d\chi^2 + f_k^2 d\Omega_{(2)}^2) \quad (31)$$

with f_k given by

$$f_k = \begin{cases} k^{-1/2} \sin(\sqrt{k}\chi) & k = 1 \\ \chi & k = 0 \\ (-k)^{-1/2} \sinh(\sqrt{-k}\chi) & k = -1 \end{cases} \quad (32)$$

which can be further compressed into

$$f_k = (k)^{-1/2} \sin(\sqrt{k}\chi) \quad (33)$$

which exploits the known limit for $k = 0$ for the sine and the definition of the hyperbolic sine for $k = -1$.

4.2 FRIEDMANN-ROBERTSON-WALKER METRICS

At this point we have all the elements needed to reintroduce time back into the picture

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a^2(t) \tilde{g}_{ij} dx^i dx^j = -dt^2 + dl^2 \quad (34)$$

If the Universe is spatially homogeneous and isotropic at all times, and if distances are allowed to expand or contract as a function of time only⁶, there's only one metric possible and is the FLRW metric:

$$ds^2 = -dt^2 + a(t)^2 \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\Omega_{(2)}^2 \right) \quad (35)$$

Since $ds^2 = g_{\mu\nu} dx^\mu dx^\nu$, the elements of the metric tensor can be read directly from (35)

$$\begin{aligned} g_{00} &= -1 \\ g_{rr} &= \frac{a^2}{1 - kr^2} \\ g_{\theta\theta} &= r^2 a^2 \\ g_{\phi\phi} &= a^2 r^2 \sin^2 \theta \end{aligned}$$

while g_{0i} and off-diagonal terms of g_{ij} are vanishing.

From the coefficient of the metric, we can also compute Christoffel's symbols

$$\Gamma_{\mu\nu}^\alpha = \frac{1}{2} g^{\lambda\alpha} (\partial_\mu g_{\lambda\nu} + \partial_\nu g_{\mu\lambda} - \partial_\lambda g_{\mu\nu}) \quad (36)$$

⁶ This is an inevitable consequence of the request of having a metric that is isotropic and homogeneous, for if all points didn't evolve at the same rate, it would be impossible for the Universe to be isotropic.

which have been reported in Appendix C.

Sometimes it is useful to perform a slight manipulation of the FLRW metric (35) and define a conformal time

$$a(\eta)d\eta = dt \quad (37)$$

so that the metric is, guess what, conformal.

Conformal Metric

Two metrics are conformal if there exists a conformal transformation such that

$$\tilde{g}_{\mu\nu} = \Omega(\eta)g_{\mu\nu}$$

and the metric $g_{\mu\nu}$ has no explicit dependence on the η parameter.

The scale factor a is therefore factorized and (35) becomes

$$ds^2 = a(\eta)^2 \left(-d\eta^2 + \frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\Omega_{(2)}^2 \right) \quad (38)$$

Note that the quantity within parentheses is independent of the conformal time. On top of that, if $k = 0$ (flat space), the FLRW metric is conformal to a Minkowski metric, and the metric is said "conformally flat".

4.2.1 Geodesics

Consider a particle initially at rest in a FLRW metric (35). The geodesics equation for such a particle will be

$$\frac{d^2 x^i}{d\tau^2} = -\Gamma_{00}^i \frac{dx^0}{d\tau} \frac{dx^0}{d\tau} \quad (39)$$

since $dx^i/d\tau = 0$, where τ is the particle's proper time. However, since $\Gamma_{00}^i = 0$, the particle isn't accelerated and its radial coordinate remains constant!

Note that what remains constant is actually the particles *comoving coordinate*, while its *proper distance* calculated from some origin of the coordinate system changes because of the time-evolution of the scale factor a .

Once a system of axis is fixed so that a given point $P_1 = (r_1, 0, 0)$, we can define its proper distance as

$$d(r, t) = \int_0^{r_1} dl(r) \quad (40)$$

where $dl(r)$ is the line element induced on the manifold, in our case

$$dl^2 = a(t)^2 \left(\frac{dr^2}{1 - kr^2} + r^2 d\Omega_{(2)}^2 \right) \quad (41)$$

Ignoring the angular dependence, i.e. a point object for which $d\Omega = 0$, the proper distance is

$$d(r, t) = \int_0^{r_1} \frac{a(t) dr}{(1 - kr^2)^{1/2}} \quad (42)$$

which is solved by

$$d(r, t) = a(t) \begin{cases} \arcsin(r_1), & k = 1 \\ r_1, & k = 0 \\ \operatorname{arcsinh}(r_1), & k = -1 \end{cases} \quad (43)$$

Please note that unlike done by other textbooks, like [3], here the scale factor a has the dimension of a length rather than being adimensional. You can think of it as the result of the product between an adimensional scale factor (which is the one really changing) and the curvature radius of the Universe at some time.

Let us now consider a free particle with non-vanishing initial momentum. The general geodesics equation is

$$\frac{d^2 x^\sigma}{d\tau^2} = -\Gamma_{\mu\nu}^\sigma \frac{dx^\mu}{d\tau} \frac{dx^\nu}{d\tau} \quad (44)$$

It's useful to remember the definition of the 4-momentum $p^\mu = mu^\mu = m dx^\mu / d\tau$ (valid for timelike paths, at least), from which we know that

$$|\vec{p}|^2 = m^2 g_{ij} \frac{dx^i}{d\tau} \frac{dx^j}{d\tau}$$

If we consider a system of coordinates such that at the instant considered the particles is arbitrarily close to the center of the coordinate system, the metric can thus be approximated as $\tilde{g}_{ij} = \delta_{ij} + o(x^2)$, where we're essentially neglecting the scalar product contribution to (21).

Then the Christoffel symbol $\Gamma_{jl}^i \propto \partial_l g_j^i \propto o(x)$ is negligible, since the space is always locally flat for each point we choose arbitrarily close to the origin.

The geodesics equation can be thus expanded

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{d^2 x^i}{d\tau^2} &= -\Gamma_{\mu\nu}^i \frac{dx^\mu}{d\tau} \frac{dx^\nu}{d\tau} = -2\Gamma_{0j}^i \frac{dx^j}{d\tau} \frac{dx^0}{d\tau} \\ &= -2 \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)} \delta_j^i \frac{dx^j}{d\tau} \frac{dx^0}{d\tau} \end{aligned}$$

At this point we can multiply both terms by $d\tau/dt$

$$\frac{d^2 x^i}{d\tau^2} \cdot \frac{d\tau}{dt} = -2 \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)} \delta_j^i \frac{dx^j}{d\tau} \frac{dx^0}{d\tau} \cdot \frac{d\tau}{dt} \quad (45)$$

and exploit the identity

$$\frac{dx^0}{d\tau} \cdot \frac{d\tau}{dt} = 1 \quad (46)$$

resulting in a first-order differential equation for $dx^i/d\tau$

$$\frac{d}{dt} \left(\frac{dx^i}{d\tau} \right) = -2 \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)} \frac{dx^i}{d\tau} \quad (47)$$

This equation yields as a solution $dx^i/d\tau \propto a^{-2}$, which means that $|\vec{p}|^2 \propto m^2 a^2 \cdot a^{-4} \propto a^{-2}$. This means that a massive particle "slows down" with respect to the comoving coordinates as the Universe expands!

If we instead consider a null geodesic (massless particle), we would find out that

$$|\vec{p}| = p = \frac{\hbar}{\lambda} \implies \lambda \propto a(t) \quad (48)$$

which means that the wavelength of a photon changes depending on the time at which it was emitted, resulting in an effect commonly known as *cosmological redshift*.

4.2.2 A short detour on redshift

The purpose of this section is to show that we can obtain the same results that we've obtained in the last section using a more elegant approach that makes use of the symmetry properties of GR and the FLRW metric. Incidentally, this will also allow us to introduce a most useful quantity in Cosmology, which is the redshift z .

Consider the four-velocity of comoving observers $U^\mu = (1, 0, 0, 0)$, then the metric admits a Killing tensor of the form

$$K_{\mu\nu} = a^2(g_{\mu\nu} + U_\mu U_\nu) \quad (49)$$

that you can check⁷ that it satisfies $\nabla_{(\sigma} K_{\mu\nu)} = 0$ where ∇_σ is the covariant derivative. By definition of Killing vector (the generalization to a K. tensor is straightforward), the quantity

$$K^2 = K_{\mu\nu} V^\mu V^\nu = a^2 [V_\mu V^\mu + (U_\mu V^\mu)^2] \quad (50)$$

is conserved along the geodesics. Here $V^\mu = dx^\mu/d\lambda$. For massive particles, since $V_\mu V^\mu = -1$ (note the convention on the signature of the metric), we also have

$$(V^0)^2 = 1 + |\vec{V}|^2 \quad |\vec{V}|^2 = g_{ij} V^i V^j$$

Recalling the formula for the four-velocity of the observer, we have $U_\mu V^\mu = -V^0$, so (50) implies

$$|\vec{V}| = \frac{K}{a}$$

Notice how this means that the particle "slows down" with respect to the comoving coordinates as the Universe expands. If we instead consider null geodesics (that is what we're actually interested in)

$$V_\mu V^\mu = 0 \implies U_\mu V^\mu = \frac{K}{a}$$

but for null-like particles, like photons, we can write the four-velocity as $V^\mu = (\omega, \vec{k})$. So the frequency of the photon as measured by a comoving observer is $\omega = -U_\mu V^\mu$ (remember that $c = 1$). The frequency emitted will still be given by the same functional expression but calculated in the local inertial frame of the emitter, so $\omega_{em} = -K/a_{em}$. We then find out that

$$\frac{\omega_{obs}}{\omega_{em}} = \frac{a_{em}}{a_{obs}}$$

⁷ Perhaps it was trivial, but it took me a long while to figure out and convince myself of the proof, which you'll find in Appendix D.

To make things easier we then define a quantity called *redshift* defined as

$$z_{em} = \frac{\lambda_{obs} - \lambda_{em}}{\lambda_{em}} \quad (51)$$

so that, if the observation takes place today ($a_{obs} = a_0 = 1$), we can just write

$$a_{em} = \frac{1}{1 + z_{em}} \quad (52)$$

and

$$\frac{\nu_{obs}}{\nu_{em}} = \frac{1}{1 + z_{em}} \quad (53)$$

Let's give an example. If we observe, say, a galaxy with a redshift $z = 2$, we are observing it as it was when the Universe had a scale factor $a(t_e) = 1/3$.

The redshift we observe for a distant object thus depends only on the relative scale factors at the time of emission and the time of observation. It doesn't depend on how the transition between $a(t_e)$ and $a(t_0)$ was made: All that matters is the scale factors at the time of emission and the time of observation.

Calculating the redshift through spectroscopic observations, it was possible to correlate the recession velocity of objects in the Universe to their proper distance, obtaining the so called *Hubble's law*

$$v = cz = H_0 d_p \quad (54)$$

Recent measurements [8] managed to estimate the present-day Hubble constant H_0 with great precision

$$H_0 = 72.53 \pm 0.99 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1} \quad (55)$$

from which we get an order-of-magnitude estimate of the age of the Universe

$$H_0^{-1} = 9.78 h^{-1} \text{ Gyr} \quad (56)$$

using $H_0 = 100h \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$. We can also calculate the so-called Hubble radius

$$R_H = H_0^{-1} c = 3h^{-1} \text{ Gpc} \quad (57)$$

The variable h keeps track of the dispersion on the value of H_0 produced by the different measurement technique that was implemented.

Please note that Hubble's law is only valid on relatively large scales, where the peculiar velocity of objects become much smaller than the expansion velocity at a given distance.

On a concluding note, please note that although it's a useful meter of comparison to understand what we're talking about, cosmological redshift has *nothing to do* with a Doppler shift.

In fact, even if the Universe was in an age in which $\dot{a} = 0$ and so that $H_0 = 0$, you wouldn't be able to interpret the shift in frequency as the effect of a Doppler shift ($v = 0$ after all), yet you'd still observe the shift, since $a(t) \neq 0$.

4.2.3 Hubble-Le Maître's Law

Let's get back to the definition of redshift starting from the scale factor a which we can Taylor expand for emission times t "close" to the observation time

$$a(t) = a(t_0) + \left(\frac{\partial a}{\partial t} \right)_{t_0} (t - t_0) + o((t - t_0)^2) \quad (58)$$

so that

$$a(t) = a(t_0) [1 + H_0(t - t_0) + o((t - t_0)^2)] \quad (59)$$

The expansion won't be ill-defined only if $H_0^{-1} \gg (t - t_0)$. We can now plug (59) into the definition of redshift (52)

$$z \approx H_0(t_0 - t) \implies z = \frac{H_0 d}{c} \quad (60)$$

where $d = c(t_0 - t)$ is the distance spanned by photons in the same time interval. Equation (60) is the correct way to express Hubble-Le Maître's law for not too large distances. For larger distances we would have to take into account the modification brought about by the second order term in the expansion of a , forcing us to introduce an additional parameter, the *acceleration parameter* q .

4.3 THE ROAD TO FRIEDMANN'S EQUATIONS

Conserved current for a non-collisional fluid

For the time being, let's consider a Universe completely filled with a fluid of cosmological relevance with negligible collision rate. The number of particles that make the fluid is conserved, and since the fluid must obey the Cosmological Principle, collective motion of the fluid can't have a privileged direction, hence $\langle v^i \rangle = 0$. We can thus define a 4-current vector J^μ that we will shortly prove to be conserved

Please note that we're walking, as usual, with units in which $c = 1$.

$$J^\mu = n u^\mu = n \frac{dx^\mu}{d\tau} \quad u^\mu = (u^0, \gamma \vec{v}) \quad (61)$$

where n is the number density of particles. To see how the expansion of the Universe affects the number density n we have to first compute

$$\nabla_\mu J^\mu = \partial_\mu J^\mu + \Gamma_\mu^\mu{}_\nu J^\nu \quad (62)$$

But since the metric is the FLRW, the covariant divergence of J^μ is vanishing. In fact, since J^i is zero on average, the covariant divergence is reduced to simplu

$$\partial_0 J^0 + \Gamma_i^i{}_0 J^0 = 0 \quad \Gamma_i^i{}_0 = \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \delta^i{}_i = 3 \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \quad (63)$$

which means

$$\frac{dn}{dt} = -3 \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \implies n(t) \propto a^{-3} \quad (64)$$

4.3.1 Energy-Momentum Tensor and Its Conservation

For the sake of simplicity, let's consider first the case of a flat-space. The energy-momentum tensor can be introduced from the minimal-action principle, imposing that the variation of a properly defined action functional is vanishing *on shell*⁸

$$\delta S = \delta \left[\int dt dV \mathcal{L} \left(q^{(a)}, \frac{\partial q^{(a)}}{\partial x^\mu} \right) \right] = 0 \quad (65)$$

where $\mathcal{L}$ is a lagrangian density. Computing the variation we obtain Euler-Lagrange equations

$$\partial^\mu \left(\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial^\mu q)} \right) - \frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial q} = 0 \quad (66)$$

Exploiting Noether's theorem and assuming translational invariance for the lagrangian density we could show that there exists a conserved quantity representing the 4-momentum flux crossing the fixed time hypersurfaces, whose normal vector is tangent to the flux itself

$$\partial_\nu \left[\frac{\partial \mathcal{L}}{\partial (\partial_\nu q)} \partial_\mu q - \delta_\mu^\nu \mathcal{L} \right] = \partial_\nu T_\mu^\nu = 0 \quad (67)$$

The 4-momentum is thus simply defined as the flux of the energy-momentum tensor through the hypersurfaces

$$p^\mu = \int T^{\mu\nu} dS_\nu \quad dS_\nu = dV \hat{n}_\nu \quad (68)$$

where $\hat{n}_\nu = (1, 0, 0, 0)$ is the unit vector orthogonal to the fixed-time hypersurfaces. For reasons that I'm sure won't surprise you, T^{00} is the energy density, while T^{i0} is the momentum density. Moreover, you can easily check that

$$\int_V \partial_\alpha T^{i\alpha} dV = 0 \implies \partial_t \int_V T^{i0} dV + \int_V \partial_j T^{ij} dV = 0 \quad (69)$$

Applying the divergence theorem to the second integral yields

$$\partial_t \int_V T^{i0} dV + \int_{\partial V} T^{ij} dS_j = 0 \quad (70)$$

which means that forces must be evenly balanced by the pressure arising in the fluid.

When a fluid is isotropic and homogeneous in a comoving reference frame, the fluid is said to be *perfect*. Through long, and boring, calculations (which essentially consist in transforming T^{00} and T^{ij} out of the comoving frame), you can show that a perfectly valid expression for the energy-momentum tensor of a perfect fluid is

$$T^{\mu\nu} = (p + \rho) u^\mu u^\nu + p g^{\mu\nu} \quad (71)$$

which we can also present in the form of a (1,1) tensor

$$T^\mu_\nu = g_{\alpha\nu} T^{\mu\alpha} = (p + \rho) u^\mu u_\nu + p (g^{\mu\alpha} g_{\nu\alpha}) \quad (72)$$

⁸ i.e. when calculated on the equations of motion.

Note that the components of u^μ are fixed by requiring $u_\mu u^\mu = -1$

from which we can immediately compute the trace

$$T^\mu_\mu = -(p + \rho) + 4p = 3p - \rho \quad (73)$$

What we'd like to show now is that the energy-momentum tensor (71) we've defined is conserved $\nabla_\nu T^{\mu\nu} = 0$ also if the metric is no longer that of the flat space but rather the FLRW (35). To do so, we have to prove that

$$\nabla_\nu T^{\mu\nu} = \nabla_\nu [(p + \rho)u^{\mu\nu}] + \nabla_\nu [pg^{\mu\nu}] = 0 \quad (74)$$

After exploiting metric compatibility, and expanding the covariant derivative, we can rewrite the previous expression as

$$\partial_\nu (p + \rho)u^\mu u^\nu + \partial_\nu pg^{\mu\nu} + (p + \rho) \left[\Gamma^\mu_{\nu\lambda} u^\lambda u^\nu + \Gamma^\nu_{\nu\lambda} u^\mu u^\lambda \right] \quad (75)$$

At this point we can notice that, since the fluid is comoving, $u^\mu = (1, 0, 0, 0)$, and thus

$$\Gamma^\mu_{\nu\lambda} u^\lambda u^\nu = \Gamma^\mu_{00} u^0 u^0 \quad \Gamma^\nu_{\nu\lambda} u^\mu u^\lambda = \Gamma^\nu_{\nu 0} u^\mu u^0 \quad (76)$$

But $\Gamma^\mu_{00} = 0$ for all values of μ given the FLRW metric, while the second term can be simplified as

$$\Gamma^\nu_{\nu 0} u^\mu u^0 = \frac{1}{2} g^{\nu i} \partial_0 g_{\nu i} u^\mu \quad (77)$$

Let's focus on the purely spatial component $\mu = j$, which ultimately simplifies to just $\partial_i pg^{ij}$, which is vanishing since the pressure has to be homogeneous because of the Cosmological Principle. The only non-trivial component is the temporal one $\mu = 0$, which yields

$$\partial_0(p + \rho) - \partial_0 p + \frac{p + \rho}{2} g^{ij} \partial_0 g_{ij} \quad (78)$$

The last derivative can be hand-wavily calculated expanding $g_{ij} = a^2 \tilde{g}_{ij}$, where $\tilde{g}_{ij}$ is independent of time. This way, the temporal component ultimately yields

$$\boxed{\partial_0 \rho + 3(p + \rho)H(t) = 0} \quad (79)$$

It might be worth pointing out that ρ is here an energy density rather than a matter density.

4.3.2 Ricci Tensor in a FLRW Metric

Honestly, I'm not in the mood to calculate all non-trivial components of the Riemann tensor first

$$R^\mu_{\nu\alpha\beta} = \partial_\alpha \Gamma^\mu_{\nu\beta} - \partial_\beta \Gamma^\mu_{\nu\alpha} + \Gamma^\mu_{\sigma\alpha} \Gamma^\sigma_{\nu\beta} - \Gamma^\mu_{\sigma\beta} \Gamma^\sigma_{\nu\alpha} \quad (80)$$

to then calculate Ricci's $R_{\nu\beta} = R^\alpha_{\nu\alpha\beta}$. You can find all non-trivial components of the Ricci tensor in Appendix C. Without doing all the troublesome calculations, I'll just say that in principle the calculation is made a little easier if we consider small deviations from flat-space for the time independent metric $\tilde{g}_{ij} = g_{ij}/a^2$, which helps significantly to decrease the effort.

It is worth mentioning, however, that we might as well expect the components R_{0i} to be vanishing because of the request of homogeneity and isotropy. An elegant way of proving it without losing your wits in the process might be considering the "inverted" version of Einstein's equation

$$R_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G \left(T_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2} T g_{\mu\nu} \right) \quad (81)$$

where T is the trace of the energy-momentum tensor. From here is trivial to prove our previous claim if we assume $T_{\mu\nu}$ to be the energy momentum tensor of a perfect fluid as seen by a comoving observer.

For future reference, I'm going to write the non-trivial components of the Ricci tensor down below

$$R_{00} = -\frac{3\ddot{a}}{a} \quad R_{ij} = \frac{1}{a^2} (2k + a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2) g_{ij} \quad (82)$$

4.3.3 Friedmann's Equation

Consider the non-canonical form of Einstein's equation (81). The trace of the energy momentum tensor is (71), and its trace is $T = 3p - \rho$, so it's immediate to solve Einstein's equation.

The temporal component yields

$$\boxed{\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}(\rho + 3p)} \quad (83)$$

Since we have three independent variables and only two viable equations⁹, we're in the need of introducing an equation of state (EoS) that relates the pressure to the energy density. Cosmology usually deals with dilute gases, for which the equation of state is simple.

For substances of cosmological importance

$$p = w\rho \quad (84)$$

where w is a dimensionless number. The behaviors of our favorite sources are summarized in the following table

	w_i
matter	0
radiation	$\frac{1}{3}$
curvature	$-\frac{1}{3}$
vacuum	-1

With our newly gained EoS in mind, we can rewrite Friedmann equation as

$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}\rho(1 + w) \quad (85)$$

⁹ The equations are actually 3: Two Friedmann equations and the equation coming from the conservation of the temporal component of the energy-momentum tensor. The three of them are not independent, since they're related through Bianchi's identity.

which tells us that the Universe is accelerating if and only if

$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} > 0 \iff w < -\frac{1}{3} \quad (86)$$

The spatial component of (81), on the other hand, yields

$$\frac{2k}{a^2} + \frac{\ddot{a}}{a} + 2 \left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a} \right)^2 = -4\pi G(p - \rho) \quad (87)$$

where the common factor $\tilde{g}_{ij}$ was suppressed. It is customary however to subtract the 1st Friedmann equation (83) from the equation we've just derived, obtaining the 2nd Friedmann equation

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a} \right)^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3} \rho - \frac{k}{a^2} \quad (88)$$

Suppose that the Universe contains N different components, with the i -th component having an energy density ρ_i and an EoS parameter w_i . As long as there is no interaction between the different components, the fluid equation (79) must hold for each component separately. So

$$\frac{\dot{\rho}_i}{\rho_i} = -3(1 + w_i) \frac{\dot{a}(t)}{a(t)} \quad (89)$$

which can be immediately integrated. Behold:

$$\rho_i(a) = \rho_{i,0} \left(\frac{a(t)}{a(t_0)} \right)^{-3(1+w_i)} \quad (90)$$

Equation (90) implies that for (non-relativistic) matter $\rho \propto a^{-3}$, while for radiation (or relativistic matter) $\rho \propto a^{-4}$. This fact has a simple explanation: The energy density of non-relativistic matter decreases as a increases because of the expanding volume of the Universe, while relativistic matter also gets redshifted. This has also another striking consequence: There had been times when different components were equivalent!

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\rho_\Lambda(a)}{\rho_m(a)} = 1 &= \frac{\rho_{\Lambda,0}}{\rho_{m,0}} a^3 \implies a_{\Lambda,m} = \left(\frac{\rho_{m,0}}{\rho_{\Lambda,0}} \right)^{1/3} \approx 0.766 \implies z_{\Lambda,m} = 0.31 \\ \frac{\rho_m(a)}{\rho_r(a)} = 1 &= \frac{\rho_{m,0}}{\rho_{r,0}} a \implies a_{r,m} = \frac{\rho_{r,0}}{\rho_{m,0}} \approx 2.9 \cdot 10^{-4} \implies z_{r,m} = 3400 \end{aligned}$$

If the Universe contains different components with different values of w , in the limit $a \rightarrow 0$, the component with the largest value of w is dominant.

Now that we have a relation between ρ and a we can set to solve the Friedmann equation (88) in special case of a spatially flat ($k = 0$) and single-component Universe. Plugging in (90), we find

$$\dot{a}^2 = \frac{8\pi G \rho_0}{c^2} \frac{a^{-(1+3w)}}{a_0^{-(1+3w)}} \quad (91)$$

which can be solved explicitly

$$a(t) = a_0 \left(\frac{t}{t_0} \right)^{\frac{2}{3+3w}} \quad t_0 = \frac{2}{3H_0(1+w)} \quad w \neq -1 \quad (92)$$

For $w = -1$, the equation is solved by

$$a(t) = a_0 e^{\pm H_0(t-t_0)} \quad (93)$$

Also note that $\dot{a} \propto (\rho a^2)^{1/2}$ which is also proportional to $\propto a^{-(1+3w)/2}$. Hence, a fluid with $w = -1/3$ would have constant expansion rate $\dot{a}$.

A detour on conformal time

Let's now write Friedmann's equations using the conformal time $d\eta = dt/a$. Through a basic application of the chain rule

$$\frac{da}{dt} = \frac{da}{d\eta} \frac{d\eta}{dt} = a' \frac{1}{a} \quad (94)$$

where with the superscript we're indicating derivatives with respect to the conformal time. In short

$$a' = \dot{a}a \quad a'' = a(a\ddot{a} + \dot{a}a') \quad \mathcal{H} = \frac{a'}{a} = \dot{a} \quad \mathcal{H}' = a\ddot{a} \quad (95)$$

With these new variables, Friedmann's equation become

$$\mathcal{H}^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3} a^2 \rho - k \quad (96)$$

$$\mathcal{H}' = -\frac{4\pi G}{3} a^2 (\rho + 3p) \quad (97)$$

while the conformal fluid equation is

$$\rho' + 3\mathcal{H}(p + \rho) = 0 \quad (98)$$

Assuming $w \neq 1$, we can integrate the definition of conformal time (37) to obtain the scale factor as a function of the conformal time

$$\eta - \eta_0 = \int_{t_0}^t a^{-1} dt \propto \int_{t_0}^t t^{-2/3(1+w)} dt \quad (99)$$

which yields

$$a(\eta) \propto \eta^{2/1+3w} \quad (w \neq -1) \quad (100)$$

If, on the other hand, $w = -1$, the integral is trivial and we find that

$$a(\eta) \propto -\frac{1}{\eta - \eta_0} \quad (\eta - \eta_0 < 0) \quad (101)$$

4.3.4 Einstein Universe

Consider a stationary Universe for which Einstein's equation is modified to include the addition of Cosmological Constant Λ

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2}Rg_{\mu\nu} + \Lambda g_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu} \quad (102)$$

and consider the modified energy-momentum tensor $\tilde{T}_{\mu\nu}$ defined so to include the contribution of the stray Cosmological Constant

$$R_{\mu\nu} - \frac{1}{2}Rg_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G \tilde{T}_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G \left(T_{\mu\nu} - \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} g_{\mu\nu} \right) \quad (103)$$

Moreover we can compute the new energy density

$$\tilde{T}_{00} = \rho + \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \quad (104)$$

and define an energy density for vacuum

$$\rho_\Lambda = \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \quad (105)$$

Similarly, we can also calculate the new pressure exerted by the cosmological fluid

$$\tilde{p} = \tilde{T}_{ii} = \left(p - \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \right) g_{ii} = p - \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \quad (106)$$

and define the pressure for vacuum, which turns out to be

$$p_\Lambda = -\frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} = -\rho_\Lambda \quad (107)$$

So the vacuum, or Cosmological Constant, would behave like a fluid with $w = -1$. We can see what that implies if we plug this last result into Friedman's equations

$$\begin{aligned} 3\ddot{a} &= -4\pi G a (\tilde{\rho} + 3\tilde{p}) \\ a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2k &= 4\pi G a^2 (\tilde{\rho} - \tilde{p}) \end{aligned}$$

which under Einstein's assumption of a static Universe ($\dot{a} = 0$ and $\ddot{a} = 0$) imply

$$\tilde{\rho} = -3\tilde{p} \quad 2k = 4\pi G a^2 (\tilde{\rho} - \tilde{p}) \quad (108)$$

and so

$$\tilde{\rho} = \frac{3k}{8\pi G a^2} \quad \tilde{p} = -\frac{k}{8\pi G a^2} \quad (109)$$

The conditions for a static Universe thus require it to be a *closed Universe* ($k = 1$). If we assume non-relativistic matter to be the only component of $T_{\mu\nu}$, then

$$\tilde{p} = -\frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \implies \tilde{p} = -\frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} = -\frac{k}{8\pi G a^2} \quad (110)$$

and thus

$$\Lambda = \frac{k}{a^2} \quad (111)$$

This means that the physical dimension of the Universe would be fixed and equal to $a = \Lambda^{-1/2}$ ($k = 1$). This already conflicts with present observations (since $H_0 \neq 0$), but to push worse to worst, Einstein's Universe would also be unstable.

Consider in fact $\tilde{T}_{\mu\nu} = T_{\mu\nu} + T_{\mu\nu}^\Lambda$, so that

$$\tilde{\rho} = \rho_M + \rho_\Lambda \implies \rho_M = \frac{2\Lambda}{8\pi G} \quad (112)$$

You have to simply substitute (105) and the value we've found for $\tilde{p}$, using $\Lambda = a^{-2}$.

If we add a positive perturbation the scale factor $a = a_E + \Delta a$, then the matter energy density decreases

$$\rho_M = \frac{3k}{8\pi G a^2} - \frac{\Lambda}{8\pi G} \quad (113)$$

so that we could write in principle $\rho_M \rightarrow \rho_M + \Delta\rho_M$ with $\Delta\rho_M < 0$. But if we plug this into Friedmann's equation

$$\ddot{a} = -4\pi G a (\tilde{\rho}_0 + 3\tilde{p}_0 + \Delta\rho_M) = -4\pi G a \Delta\rho_M = 4\pi G a |\Delta\rho_M| > 0 \quad (114)$$

meaning that such a Universe is unstable!

Einstein-De Sitter Universe

Let's try this one more time. Recall Friedmann's second equation (88) and consider a flat Universe with only the Cosmological Constant in it

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{\Lambda}{3} \implies a(t) \propto \exp\left(\sqrt{\frac{\Lambda}{3}}t\right) \quad (115)$$

and so Hubble's constant $H = \sqrt{\Lambda/3}$. This implies

$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}(\rho_\Lambda + 3p_\Lambda) = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho_\Lambda = \frac{\Lambda}{3} \quad (116)$$

4.3.5 Critical Density

Let's write again Friedmann's second equation

$$\left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a}\right)^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3}\rho - \frac{k}{a^2} \quad (117)$$

and define the *critical energy density* as the energy density the Universe should have to be flat

$$\rho_c = \frac{3H^2}{8\pi G} \quad (118)$$

At present time, the critical density $\rho_c(t_0)$ is evaluated at $1.878 \cdot 10^{-29} h^2 \text{ g cm}^{-3}$ or, equivalently, at $1.05 \cdot 10^4 h^2 \text{ eV cm}^{-3}$.

This quantity, that will generally change with time, is called the critical density because the Friedmann equation (88) can be written as

$$\Omega - 1 = \frac{k}{H^2 a^2} \quad (119)$$

that univocally determinates the sign of k depending on whether Ω is greater then, equal to, or less than one.

$$\begin{aligned} \rho < \rho_c &\iff \Omega < 1 \iff k < 0 \iff \text{open} \\ \rho = \rho_c &\iff \Omega = 1 \iff k = 0 \iff \text{flat} \\ \rho > \rho_c &\iff \Omega > 1 \iff k > 0 \iff \text{closed} \end{aligned}$$

The density parameter Ω , then, tells us which of the three FLRW geometries describes our Universe. Since the right-hand side of (119) cannot change sign as the Universe expands, neither can the left-hand side. So, Ω will have the same sign *at all times*.

In a realistic case, we should consider a Universe with multiple components, although perhaps not interacting. We can then think of writing a total energy density

$$\rho = \sum_i \rho_i = \rho_{DM} + \rho_B + \rho_r + \rho_\Lambda + \dots \quad (120)$$

or, in terms of the density parameter(s), we could also write

$$\rho = \rho_c \sum_i \Omega_i \quad (121)$$

In these variables, the Friedmann equation (88) can be written

$$H^2 = \frac{8\pi G}{3} \sum_{i(c)} \rho_i \quad (122)$$

where the notation $\sum_{i(c)} = \Omega_0 + \sum_i \Omega_i$ indicates that we sum not only over all the actual components of energy density ρ_i , but also on the contribution of spatial curvature, which we define as

$$\Omega_0 = -\frac{k}{a^2 H^2} \quad (123)$$

Dividing both sides by H^2 yields a shockingly simple equation

$$1 = \sum_{i(c)} \Omega_i = \Omega_0 + \sum_i \Omega_i \quad (124)$$

thus producing a consistency relation that must hold at *any* time.

Acceleration Parameter

A few pages ago, back when we first proved Hubble-Le Maître's law, we've introduced, although barely, the *acceleration parameter* q , which we now define as

$$q = -\frac{\ddot{a}a}{\dot{a}^2} \quad (125)$$

I don't think I will surprise any of you saying that if $q < 0$, then the Universe is accelerating, and if it's $q > 0$, then it is decelerating. Not being surprised was what people back then expected when they first defined this quantity. They were so sure of their results that they even named it *deceleration parameter* rather than acceleration. Shortly after, they realized they should have probably changed its name.

Recall (83) with a perfect fluid EoS

$$\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} = -\frac{4\pi G}{3}\rho(1+3w) \quad (126)$$

This means that the "deceleration" parameter can be written as

$$q = \frac{4\pi G}{3H^2}\rho(1+3w) \quad (127)$$

or, equivalently, we can plug in the critical density and density parameter to find

$$q = \frac{\Omega}{2}(1+3w) \implies q = \sum_i \frac{\Omega_i}{2}(1+3w_i) \quad (128)$$

which can be studied for all the various components our Universe could feature

- $w < -1/3 \implies q < 0$ and hence the Universe accelerates;
- $w = 0 \implies q = \Omega_M/2 > 0$ and hence it decelerates. This was actually the underlying assumption in the Einstein-De Sitter Universe model;
- $w = 1/3 \implies q \approx \Omega_r > 0$;
- $w = -1 \implies q = -\Omega_\Lambda < 0$ and hence the Universe accelerates. This is what a De Sitter Universe would predict.

Vacuum Energy

Achtung! I know nothing of quantum field theory nor have any competence or background knowledge to assure you that what you'll read in this section is ontologically correct. For this, I'm merely reporting what's written in my notes.

It is the purpose of this section to briefly discuss as for why the Cosmological Constant can be considered as a vacuum energy. First of all, if we consider the Lorentz-invariant quantum void, the energy density associated to the cosmological constant should be roughly equal to present day's critical density

$$\rho_\Lambda \approx \rho_C(t_0) \approx 10^{-44} \text{ GeV}^4 \quad (129)$$

which, I'm told, assumes that

$$\langle T_{\mu\nu}^{\text{vac}} \rangle = -\langle \rho \rangle g_{\mu\nu} \iff g_{\mu\nu} \text{ is a Lorentz invariant}$$

This implies that $\rho_{\text{vac}} = \langle \rho \rangle$ and $p_{\text{vac}} = \langle p \rangle = -\rho_{\text{vac}}$. But to go any further than this we have to somehow assume a field theory of some sort

$$\langle \rho \rangle_{\text{vac}} = \int_0^{k_{\text{max}}} \frac{d^3k}{(2\pi)^3} \frac{1}{2} \sqrt{k^2 + m^2} \approx \frac{k_{\text{max}}^4}{16\pi^2} \quad (130)$$

where k_{max} is an arbitrarily-high scale at which I assume my QFT to be valid. For the sake of simplicity we can assume a system composed by a set of harmonic oscillators¹⁰ with Hamiltonian

$$H_k = \omega_k \left(n_k + \frac{1}{2} \right) \quad (131)$$

hence

$$\frac{1}{2} \omega_k = \frac{1}{2} \sqrt{k^2 + m^2} \quad (132)$$

If we assume that the highest scale possible at which our theory is valid is the Planck scale

$$k_{\text{max}} = M_{Pl} \sim 10^{19} \text{ GeV} \quad (133)$$

then the average energy density of the vacuum would be as high as $\langle \rho \rangle_{\text{vac}} \sim 10^{74} \text{ GeV}^4$, which, I'm sure you've noticed, is 120 orders of magnitude larger than the expected critical density.

If we lower our upper bound for the allowed scales to the electroweak scale $\sim 200 \text{ GeV}$, the average energy density of the vacuum would be $\langle \rho \rangle_{\text{vac}} \sim 10^7 \text{ GeV}^4$, which is still 51 orders of magnitude too large.

Researchers way more qualified than me have come up with several possible explanation for this unsettling discrepancy:

1. A fluid with negative pressure, a.k.a. *dark energy* (also, Cosmological Constant, or Quintessence);
2. A modification of GR on the very largest scales (possibly including massive gravitons);
3. Non-linear effects of GR caused by interactions over large scales, so some sort of backreaction.

¹⁰ This is the only thing I can gather about all this.

Any mismatch in units has to be attributed to the unspoken choice to use units in which $c = 1$, $k_B = 1$, and either $\hbar$ or $\hbar = 1$.

4.4 DYNAMIC AGE OF THE UNIVERSE

The actual model for the Universe, sometimes known as Benchmark model, is a Λ CDM model, where the Λ obviously stands for Cosmological Constant, while CDM stands for *Cold Dark Matter*.

We've already seen that we can write the total energy density as

$$\rho = \rho_m + \rho_r + \rho_\Lambda \quad (134)$$

which all scale differently but according to (90). This is most useful, because it allows us to write the total energy density as a function of the present-day density parameters and their associates scaling with the scale factor

$$\rho = \frac{3H_0^2}{8\pi G} \left(\Omega_{\Lambda,0} + \Omega_{r,0} \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^4 + \Omega_{m,0} \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^3 \right) \quad (135)$$

We can plug this into (88) to obtain

$$\frac{\dot{a}^2}{a_0^2 H_0^2} + \frac{k}{a_0^2 H_0^2} = \frac{8\pi G}{3H_0^2} \left(\frac{a}{a_0} \right)^2 \rho \quad (136)$$

It might be useful to define and introduce the parameter $x = a(t)/a_0 = 1/(1+z(t))$ which lives in the range $0 \leq x \leq 1$ since $a(t) \leq a_0$ (we're only looking back). With a realistic model, such as the Benchmark, we can safely put $k = 0$ and simplify the equation

$$\frac{\dot{a}^2}{a_0^2 H_0^2} = \left(\frac{a}{a_0} \right)^2 \left(\Omega_{\Lambda,0} + \Omega_{r,0} \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^4 + \Omega_{m,0} \left(\frac{a_0}{a} \right)^3 \right) \quad (137)$$

which we can rewrite as

$$\frac{H^2}{H_0^2} \cdot x^2 = x^2 \left[\Omega_{\Lambda,0} + \Omega_{m,0} x^{-3} + \Omega_{r,0} x^{-4} \right] = x^2 E(x)^2 \quad (138)$$

and further manipulate

$$\frac{H}{H_0} x = x E(x) \rightarrow \frac{1}{a} \dot{a} \frac{1}{H_0} x = x E(x) \rightarrow \frac{1}{a_0} \frac{da}{dt} \frac{1}{H_0} = x E(x) \quad (139)$$

But since, by virtue of its own definition, we have

$$dx = \frac{da}{a_0} \rightarrow dt = \frac{dx}{x H_0 E(x)} \quad (140)$$

This we can easily integrate from $x = 0$ ($t = 0$, which corresponds to the BBN in the standard model of the Hot Big Bang)

$$t(x) = \int_0^x dt = \int_0^x \frac{dx'}{x' H_0 E(x')} \quad (141)$$

which represents the *dynamical age of the Universe*. Sometimes it might be useful to express it in terms of the redshift z so that

$$E^2(z) = \Omega_{\Lambda,0} + \Omega_{m,0}(1+z)^3 + \Omega_{r,0}(1+z)^4 \quad dx = \frac{-dz}{(1+z)^2} \quad (142)$$

The dynamical age in terms of the redshift is then

$$t(z) = \frac{1}{H_0} \int_z^\infty \frac{dz'}{(1+z')E(z')} \quad (143)$$

For the Einstein-De Sitter Universe ($k = 0$, $\Omega_{m,0} = 1$), the dynamical time evaluates to

$$t_0^{E-dS} = \frac{1}{H_0} \int_0^1 \frac{dx}{x \cdot x^{-3/2}} = \frac{2}{3H_0} \approx 7.0h^{-1} \text{ Gyr} \quad (144)$$

which is smaller than a Hubble time H_0^{-1} . The dynamical time produced by a E-dS Universe is way too short: It's in tension with the estimated age of some structures and/or unstable chemical elements which we can still observe (e.g., radionuclids with decay time of about 10 – 15 Gyr). It is also in high tension with the estimated age of some old white dwarves and with the estimated age we've obtained from the temperature fluctuations of the CMB.

For a realistic Λ CDM model ($k = 0$, $\Omega_{r,0} \sim 0$, and $\Omega_{\Lambda,0} + \Omega_{m,0} \sim 1$), the dynamical time is evaluated to

$$\begin{aligned} t_0 &\approx \frac{1}{H_0} \int_0^1 \frac{dx}{x(\Omega_{\Lambda,0} + \Omega_{m,0}x^{-3})^{1/2}} \\ &= \frac{1}{H_0\Omega_{\Lambda,0}^{1/2}} \int_0^1 \frac{dx}{x(1 + (\frac{1}{\Omega_{\Lambda,0}} - 1)x^{-3})^{1/2}} \end{aligned}$$

which yields

$$t_0 = \frac{2}{3H_0} \frac{1}{\Omega_{\Lambda,0}^{1/2}} \ln \left[\frac{1 + \Omega_{\Lambda,0}^{1/2}}{(1 - \Omega_{\Lambda,0})^{1/2}} \right] \sim 14 \text{ Gyr} \quad (145)$$

4.5 INFLATION

Coming soon.

5

THERMAL HISTORY OF THE UNIVERSE

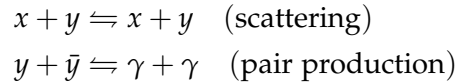
For a significant part of this chapter, I'll be mainly following [1]. Please note that for some reason I cannot fathom, Baumann is using the metric signature $(+, -, -, -)$, which is the exact opposite of what we've been using in the previous chapters.

The key to understanding the thermal history of the Universe is the comparison between the rate of interactions Γ and the rate of expansion H . When $\Gamma \gg H$, then the time scale of particle interactions is much smaller than the characteristic expansion time scale

$$t_c = \frac{1}{\Gamma} \ll t_H = \frac{1}{H} \quad (146)$$

and Local Thermal Equilibrium (LTE) is reached before the effect of the expansion becomes relevant. As the Universe cools, the rate of interactions may decrease faster than the expansion rate. At $t_c \sim t_H$, the particles decouple from the thermal bath. Different particle species may have different interaction rates and so may decouple at different times.

The reactions we'll be interested in looking into are those of the likes



We mark the beginning of the thermal history of the Universe at $(k)T \sim 1 \text{ MeV}$, which roughly corresponds to 1s after the Big Bang. So we'll implicitly assume that quarks are already confined within hadrons, which are already slowed to a non-relativistic regime (while photons, electrons, and neutrinos have not).

Baryon to Photon Ratio

For future reference, let's define now the *Baryon to Photon ratio* η . Provided that photons are not created or destroyed, but merely red-shifted, $n_\gamma \propto a^{-3}$. Similarly, if baryons are not destroyed during the evolution of the Universe (that is, they are stable and do not annihilate), their number density merely gets diluted $n_{\text{Baryon}} \propto a^{-3}$. Therefore

$$\eta = n_{\text{Baryon}} / n_\gamma$$

is constant and approximately equal to $\eta \approx 6.1 \cdot 10^{-10}$.

5.0.1 Statistical Properties

Before getting knee-deep into calculations, let's take a moment to recall some statistical properties and properties in general which we'll be using extensively in the following.

First of all, recall the Bose-Einstein/Fermi-Dirac distribution function ($c = \hbar = 1$)

$$f(p, T) = \frac{1}{\exp\left(\frac{E(p) - \mu}{kT}\right) \pm 1} \quad (147)$$

where the $+$ identifies the Fermi-Dirac distribution, and the $-$ the Bose-Einstein distribution. We'll be always working under conditions for which $\mu \ll kT$, so we can drop it from (147). That being the case, we can define the particle numeric density

$$n = \frac{g}{h^3} \int d^3p f(p, T) \quad (148)$$

and the associated energy density

$$\rho(T) = \frac{g}{h^3} \int d^3p E(p) f(p, T) \quad (149)$$

We can assume an isotropic distribution for the momentum $d^3p = 4\pi p^2 dp$, and define $m = xT$ and $p = \xi T$, so that the integrals in (148) and (149) can be expressed as

$$n(T) = \frac{g}{h} T^3 I_{\pm} \quad \rho(T) = \frac{g}{h} T^4 J_{\pm} \quad (150)$$

where $I_{\pm}$ and $J_{\pm}$ are the two integral functions reported below

$$I_{\pm} = \int_0^{\infty} d\xi \frac{\xi^2}{\exp\left(\sqrt{x^2 + \xi^2}\right) \pm 1} \quad J_{\pm} = \int_0^{\infty} d\xi \frac{\xi^2 \sqrt{x^2 + \xi^2}}{\exp\left(\sqrt{x^2 + \xi^2}\right) \pm 1} \quad (151)$$

In the relativistic limit ($x \rightarrow 0$, $m \ll (k)T$) the equation for $I_{\pm}$ can be solved explicitly

$$\begin{aligned} I_{\pm}(x=0) &= \int_0^{\infty} \frac{\xi^2}{\exp(\xi) \pm 1} d\xi \\ &= \sum_{j=1}^{\infty} (\mp 1)^{j-1} \int_0^{\infty} \xi^2 e^{-j\xi} d\xi = \begin{cases} 2\zeta(3) & (-) \\ \frac{3}{2}\zeta(3) & (+) \end{cases} \end{aligned}$$

where $\zeta(x)$ is the Riemann ζ -function. Hence we get for the particle density

$$\boxed{\frac{\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} g T^3 \begin{cases} 1 & \text{bosons} \\ \frac{3}{4} & \text{fermions} \end{cases}} \quad (152)$$

A similar computation for the energy density gives

$$\boxed{\frac{\pi^2}{30} g T^4 \begin{cases} 1 & \text{bosons} \\ \frac{7}{8} & \text{fermions} \end{cases}} \quad (153)$$

In the non-relativistic limit, on the other hand, we have $x \gg 1$, and the integral is the same for both bosons and fermions

$$I_{\pm}(x) = J_{\pm} \approx \int_0^{\infty} \frac{\xi^2}{\exp\left(\sqrt{\xi^2 + x^2}\right)} d\xi \quad (154)$$

As often happens, what's really important for you to remember it's not the whole expression, but rather the characteristic scaling of quantities. In this particular case, you should commit to memory $n \propto T^3$ and $\rho \propto T^4$.

Most of the contribution to the integral comes from $\xi \ll x$. After Taylor-expanding the square root in the exponential to lowest order in ξ , we obtain

$$I_{\pm}(x) = \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}} x^{3/2} e^{-x} \quad (155)$$

which introduces a Boltzmann-like suppression

$$n(T) = g \left(\frac{mT}{2\pi} \right)^{3/2} e^{-m/T} \quad \rho(T) = mn + \frac{3}{2}nT \quad (156)$$

Note that in the expression for the energy density, the bulk of the contribution comes from the term mn .

As expected, massive particles are exponentially rare at low temperatures, $(k)T \ll m$.

5.0.2 Effective Number of Relativistic Species

Let T be the temperature of the photon gas. The total radiation density is the sum over the energy densities of all relativistic species

$$\rho_r = \sum_i \frac{g_i}{2\pi^2} T_i^4 J_{\pm}(x_i = \frac{m_i}{T_i}) := \frac{\pi^2}{30} g_{\star} T_{\gamma}^4 \quad (157)$$

where $g_{\star}$ is the *effective number of relativistic degrees of freedom* at the temperature T , assumed identical for all the different relativistic species. The definition for the effective number of relativistic degrees of freedom is the following

$$g_{\star} = \sum_i g_i \left(\frac{T_i}{T_{\gamma}} \right)^4 \frac{J_{\pm}(x_i)}{J_{\pm}(0)} \quad (158)$$

It might be useful to differentiate the relativistic species in thermal equilibrium with the photons

$$g_{\star}^{\text{th}} = \sum_{i=b} g_i + \frac{7}{8} \sum_{i=f} g_i \quad (159)$$

from the relativistic species that are *not* in thermal equilibrium with the photons

$$g_{\star}^{\text{dec}} = \sum_{i=b} g_i \left(\frac{T_i}{T_{\gamma}} \right)^4 + \frac{7}{8} \sum_{i=f} \left(\frac{T_i}{T_{\gamma}} \right)^4 g_i \quad (160)$$

When the temperature drops below the mass m_i of a particle species, it becomes non-relativistic and is removed from the sum. Away from mass thresholds, the thermal contribution is independent of temperature.

The evolution of $g_{\star}$ assuming the Standard Model particle content is better represented with a plot, that is often clearer than dozens of lines of calculations. You can find this plot in Fig.2.

Counting DoFs

As I mentioned in some earlier chapter, I know pretty much nothing about QFT and stuff. But since I think it is at least interesting to see how the computation is done, I'll rely on someone who knows better than me, namely Mr. Baumann.

At $(k)T \gtrsim 100 \text{ GeV}$, all particles of the Standard Model are relativistic. Adding up their internal degrees of freedom we get

- $g_b = 28$: Photons (2), $W^\pm$ and Z^0 ($3 \cdot 3$), gluons ($8 \cdot 2$), and Higgs (1);
- $g_f = 90$: Quarks ($6 \cdot 12$), charged leptons ($3 \cdot 4$), and neutrinos ($3 \cdot 2$).

hence $g_\star = g_b + 7g_f/8 = 106.75$. As the temperature drops, various particle species become non-relativistic and annihilate. To estimate $g_\star$ at a temperature T you simply add up the contributions from all relativistic degrees of freedom and discard the rest.

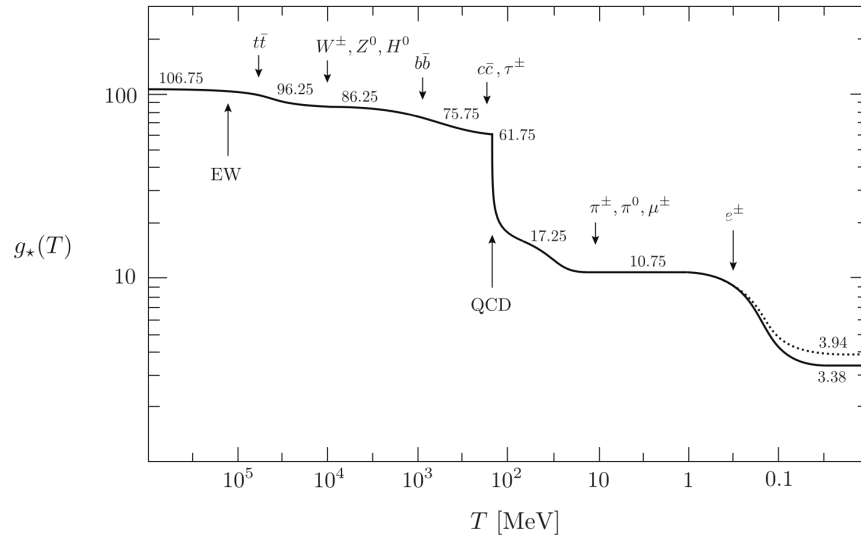


Figure 2: Evolution of relativistic degrees of freedom $g_\star(T)$ assuming the Standard Model particle content. The dotted line stands for the number of effective degrees of freedom in entropy $g_{*S}(T)$. Credits: [1].

5.0.3 Conservation of Entropy

In the field of cosmology, entropy is often more informative than energy. According to the second law of thermodynamics, the total entropy of the Universe only increases or stays constant. Since there are far more photons than baryons in the Universe, the entropy of the Universe is dominated by the entropy of the photon bath (at least as long as the Universe is sufficiently uniform). Any entropy production from non-equilibrium processes is therefore total insignificant relative to the total entropy.

To a good approximation we can therefore treat the expansion of the Universe as *adiabatic*, so that the total entropy stays constant even beyond equilibrium.

Consider

$$T dS = dU + p dV \quad (161)$$

and define the entropy and energy density respectively as $s = S/V$ and $\rho = U/V$. The equation above thus becomes

$$T d(sV) = d(\rho V) + p dV \quad (162)$$

whence

$$(Ts - \rho - p) dV + V \left(T \frac{ds}{dT} - \frac{d\rho}{dT} \right) dT = 0 \quad (163)$$

So that the identity can be verified it's necessary that

$$s = \frac{p + \rho}{T} \quad (164)$$

from which

$$\frac{ds}{dT} = \frac{1}{T} \frac{d\rho}{dT} \rightarrow \frac{ds}{dt} = \frac{1}{T} \frac{d\rho}{dt} \quad (165)$$

Recall the continuity equation stemming from the FRLW metric (79)

$$\dot{\rho} = -3(p + \rho)H = -3HsT \quad (166)$$

We're thus able to conclude by simple substitution that

$$\boxed{\frac{d}{dt}(sa^3) = 0} \quad (167)$$

It is also possible to show that the entropy density is related to temperature and to the degrees of freedom of the Universal bath by means of

$$s = \frac{2\pi^2}{45} g_{\star}^s(T) T^3 \quad (168)$$

where we've defined the *effective number of degrees of freedom in entropy*

$$g_{\star}^s = \sum_{i=b} g_i \left(\frac{T_i}{T} \right)^3 + \frac{7}{8} \sum_{i=f} g_i \left(\frac{T_i}{T} \right)^3 \quad (169)$$

Note that for species in thermal equilibrium $g_{\star S}^{\text{th}}(T) = g_{\star}^{\text{th}}(T)$. However, given that $s_i \propto T_i^3$, only for decoupled species we get (169). Hence, $g_{\star S}$ is equal to $g_{\star}$ only when all the relativistic species are in equilibrium at the same temperature.

Substituting (168) into (167)

$$\frac{d}{dt}(g_{\star S} a^3 T^3) = 0 \quad (170)$$

which gives us an expression for the Universe's cooling law! In fact, assuming $g_{\star S} \approx \text{const.}$ (reasonable for temperatures away from particle mass thresholds), we get

$$\boxed{T \propto \frac{1}{a} \propto 1 + z} \quad (171)$$

Such scaling relation is surely valid after the last scattering epoch (which we'll be shortly introducing), though it's worth pointing out that this conservation law doesn't include the hyperfine details of irreversible reactions on the smaller scales.

Note that we're implicitly assuming $k \sim 0$ (flat Universe), so that $\Omega_0 = 0$. We're also using the Planck mass $M_{Pl} = \sqrt{\hbar c / 8\pi G}$.

Substituting $T \propto g_{\star S}^{-1/3} a^{-1}$ into Friedmann's equation we find

$$H = \frac{\dot{a}}{a} \approx \left(\frac{\rho_r}{3M_{Pl}^2} \right)^{1/2} \approx \frac{\pi}{3} \left(\frac{g_{\star}}{10} \right)^{1/2} \frac{T^2}{M_{Pl}} \quad (172)$$

which for a RD Universe reproduces the usual result $a \propto t^{1/2}$, except that there is a change in the scaling every time $g_{\star S}$ changes. For $T \propto t^{-1/2}$ (as follows from $H = 1/2t$) we can integrate the Friedmann equation and get the temperature as a function of time

$$\left(\frac{T}{\text{MeV}} \right) \approx 1.5 g_{\star}^{-1/4} \left(\frac{1 \text{ s}}{t} \right)^{1/2} \quad (173)$$

5.1 NEUTRINO DECOUPLING

Neutrinos are coupled to the thermal bath via weak interaction processes like

$$\begin{aligned} e^- + \nu_e &\rightleftharpoons e^- + \nu_e \quad (\text{electron scattering}) \\ e^- + e^+ &\rightleftharpoons \nu_e + \bar{\nu}_e \quad (\text{pair production}) \end{aligned}$$

Consider the production rate $\Gamma = n\sigma v \approx H$ (at decoupling). We know that during RD, the Hubble constant was approximately equal to

$$H^2 = \frac{\pi^2}{90} g_{\star} \frac{T^4}{M_{Pl}^2} \quad (174)$$

Moreover, relativistic neutrinos have a particle density given by the fermionic version of (152), and their decoupling temperature is significantly lower than the electroweak mass-scale m_{ω} , which means that the cross-section for the interaction is given by $\sigma = G_F^2 T^2$.

Putting everything together we find out that the interaction rate $\Gamma \propto T^5$, while the Hubble constant $H \propto T^2$, which means that equivalence can be reached! And indeed we can quickly produce a temperature at neutrinos decoupling

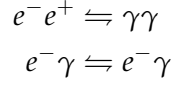
Watch out! This is a typical question that is asked during the oral exam!

$$T_d \sim \left(\frac{1}{M_{Pl} G_F^2} \right)^{1/3} \sim \text{MeV} \quad (175)$$

After decoupling, the neutrinos move freely along geodesics and preserve to an excellent approximate the relativistic Fermi-Dirac distribution (even after they become non-relativistic at later times).

5.2 ELECTRON-POSITRON ANNIHILATION

Shortly after the neutrinos decouple, the temperature drops below the electron mass and electron-positron annihilation occurs (along with Compton scattering that keeps electron coupled to photons)



This, however, is not a decoupling! As temperature decreases, the equilibrium position of the annihilation reaction moves towards the photons, due to the decreasing energy to support the pair production. The energy density and entropy of the electrons and positrons are transferred to the photons, but not to the decoupled neutrinos. The photons are thus “heated” (the photon temperature does not decrease as much) relative to the neutrinos.

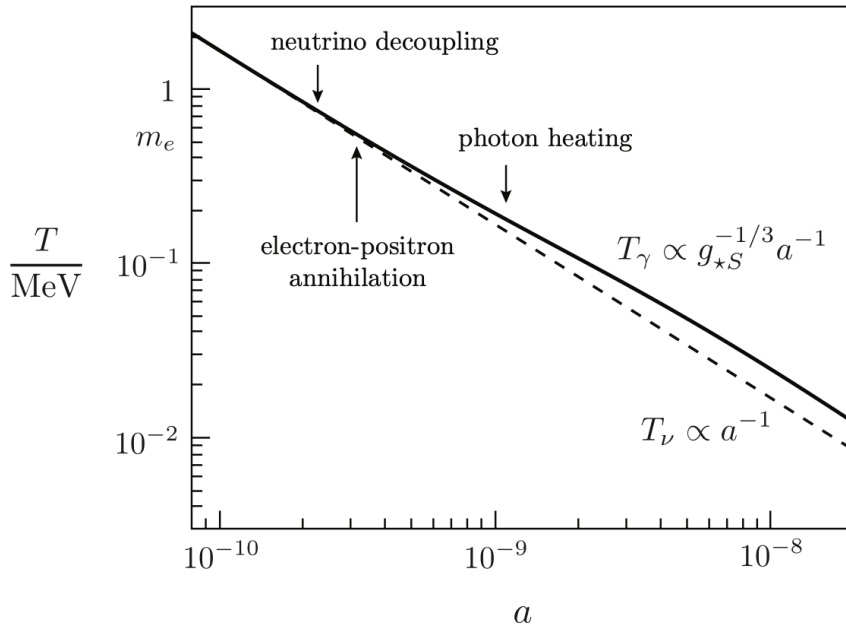


Figure 3: Thermal history through electron-positron annihilation. Neutrinos are decoupled and their temperature redshifts simply as $T_\nu \propto a^{-1}$. The energy density of the electron-positron pairs is transferred to the photon gas whose temperature therefore redshifts more slowly, $T_\gamma \propto g_{*S}^{-1/3} a^{-1}$. Credits: [1].

Let's do a quick entropic balance, assuming $T_\gamma^I = T_\nu^I$, which along with $a^3 T_\gamma^3 g_{*S} = \text{const.}$, allows us to compute it separately for both coupled and uncoupled species.

Fix the scale parameter a and assume an adiabatic process, and if we neglect neutrinos and other decoupled species, we get

$$g_{*S}^{th} = \begin{cases} 2 + \frac{7}{8} \cdot 4 = \frac{11}{2} & (k)T \gtrsim m \quad (\gamma, e^-, e^+ \text{ with their spins}) \\ 2 & (k)T \lesssim m \quad (\gamma \text{ and their polarizations}) \end{cases} \quad (176)$$

This means that the temperature of photons before and after annihilation is in the ratio

$$\frac{T_\gamma^I}{T_\gamma^F} = \left(\frac{4}{11} \right)^{1/3} \approx 0.7 \quad (177)$$

This also means that the temperature of neutrinos is slightly lower than the photon temperature after e^+e^- annihilation

$$\boxed{\frac{T_\nu^F}{T_\gamma^F} = \left(\frac{4}{11}\right)^{1/3}} \quad (178)$$

This is because, in equilibrium, $g_{*S}^{th}(aT_\gamma)^3$ remains constant, and we later find that aT_γ increases after electron-positron annihilation, $(k)T < m_e$, by a factor $(11/4)^{1/3}$, while aT_ν remains the same since neutrinos are decoupled.

The present-time temperature of photons is measured from the CMB, $T_\gamma(t_0) = 2.7$ K, while the predicted neutrino temperature for a CvB (*cosmic neutrino background*) is $T_\nu(t_0) = 1.95$ K (yet to be confirmed experimentally). The associated particle densities are quickly found

$$n_\gamma \sim g_\gamma T_\gamma^3 \quad n_\nu \sim \frac{3}{4} g_\nu T_\nu^3 \quad (179)$$

We can write the latter in terms of the former using the temperature ratio we've previously found

$$n_\nu = \frac{3}{4} \left(\frac{4}{11} n_\gamma\right) \approx 112 \text{ cm}^{-3} \quad (\text{per flavour}) \quad (180)$$

At the predicted temperature for the CvB, two out of three neutrino flavours would be non-relativistic. But that's not a big problem since the scaling of density with temperature is already fixed (they've long since decoupled).

Cosmologic Bound to Neutrino Masses

Achtung! Neutrinos, while the Universe expanded, have turned non-relativistic, that's why we're using $\rho \approx mn$.

Consider the density parameter $\Omega_\nu(t_0)$ for neutrinos

$$\Omega_\nu(t_0) = \frac{\rho_\nu(t_0)}{\rho_c} = \frac{\sum_i m_{\nu,i} n_{\nu,i}(t_0)}{\rho_c} \quad (181)$$

which yields

$$\boxed{\Omega_\nu(t_0) h^2 \approx \frac{\sum_i m_{\nu,i}}{94 \text{ eV}}} \quad (182)$$

where we've used $H_0 = 100h \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}$ and $h = 0.695$. By demanding that neutrinos don't over close the universe, i.e. $\Omega_\nu < 1$, we can give a cosmological upper bound on the sum of the neutrino masses

$$\sum_i m_{\nu,i} \leq 14 - 15 \text{ eV} \quad (183)$$

while from the combined effort of the Planck collaboration and analysis of BAO¹ we get an ever more strict upper bound $\sum_i m_{\nu,i} \leq 0.13 \text{ eV}$. On the other hand, we also have a lower bound given by neutrinos oscillations

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_i m_{\nu,i} &\geq 0.06 \text{ eV} \quad (\text{normal ordering}) \\ \sum_i m_{\nu,i} &\geq 0.1 \text{ eV} \quad (\text{inverted ordering}) \end{aligned}$$

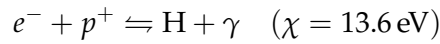
¹ Baryonic Acoustic Oscillations.

5.3 PHOTON RECOMBINATION AND DECOUPLING

An important event in the history of the early Universe is the formation of the first atoms. At temperatures above about 1 eV, the Universe still consisted of a plasma of free electrons and nuclei. Photons were tightly coupled to the electrons via Compton scattering, which in turn strongly interacted with protons via Coulomb scattering. There was very little neutral hydrogen. When the temperature became low enough, the electrons and nuclei combined to form neutral atoms (*recombination*), and the density of free electrons fell sharply.

5.3.1 Hydrogen recombination

What we're going to look into now is the recombination reaction of Hydrogen²



Clearly, the electrons participating in such reaction are those that had survived annihilation. We can write a chemical balance for the species involved

$$\frac{n_H}{n_e n_p} = \frac{g_H}{g_e g_p} \left(\frac{m_H}{m_e m_p} \frac{2\pi}{T} \right)^{3/2} \exp \left(\frac{m_p + m_e - m_H}{(k)T} \right) \exp \left(\frac{\mu_p + \mu_e - \mu_H}{(k)T} \right) \quad (184)$$

In the prefactor, we can use $m_H \approx m_p$, but in the exponential the small difference between m_H and $m_p + m_e$ is crucial.

but both the ratio of the state degeneracies g and the exponential of the chemical potentials are equal to 1 at equilibrium. If the Universe is globally neutral, then $n_e = n_p$. Also, we can introduce the *free electron fraction*

$$X_e = \frac{n_e}{n_e + n_H} = \frac{n_e}{n_p + n_H} = \frac{n_e}{n_b} = \frac{n_e}{\eta n_\gamma} \quad (185)$$

where in the last equality we have introduced the baryon to photon ratio η . To simplify the discussion, let us ignore all nuclei other than protons (over 90% (by number) of the nuclei are protons). The total baryon number density can then be approximated as $n_b \approx n_p + n_H = n_e + n_H$ and hence

$$\frac{1 - X_e}{X_e^2} = \frac{n_b n_H}{n_e^2} \quad (186)$$

which, plugged in the equation for chemical balance (184), yields the celebrated *Saha equation*

$$\left(\frac{1 - X_e}{X_e^2} \right)_{\text{eq}} = \frac{2\eta\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} T^3 \left(\frac{2\pi}{m_e k T} \right)^{3/2} \exp \left(\frac{m_p + m_e - m_H}{(k)T} \right) \quad (187)$$

As a matter of fact, at times Saha's equation is written simply as

$$1 - X_e(T) = f(t) X_e^2(T) \quad (188)$$

From here we can essentially choose an arbitrary threshold for when we can consider the Universe "recombined." Some choose the moment at which

² Technically speaking, we should also consider the recombination reaction for Helium.

$X_e \leq 0.5$, while others choose $X_e \leq 0.1$; you choose, the resulting difference is minimal. Following Baumann, we find a recombination temperature

$$T_{\text{rec}} = 0.3 \text{ eV} \approx 3600 \text{ K} \quad (189)$$

Please notice that $T_{\text{rec}} < \chi = 13.6 \text{ eV}$, since there are very many photons for each Hydrogen atom and the high-energy tail of the photon distribution contains photons with energy larger the ionization threshold, allowing Hydrogen ionization.

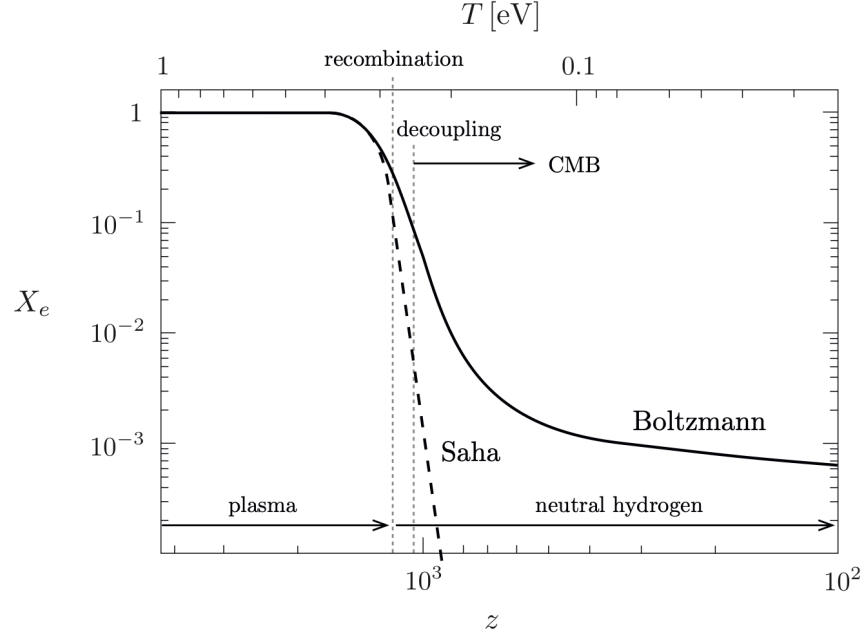


Figure 4: Free electron fraction as a function of redshift. The horizontal axis is reversed to replicate the natural flow of time from left to right. Credits: [1].

Using $T_{\text{rex}} = T_0(1 + z_{\text{rec}})$, with $T_0 = 2.7 \text{ K}$, gives the redshift of recombination

$$z_{\text{rec}} \approx 1320 \quad (190)$$

Since matter-radiation equality is at $z_{\text{eq}} \approx 3500$, we conclude that recombination occurred in the matter-dominated era.

On an ending note, notice how thanks to Boltzmann's contribution in the non-relativistic regime the ionization fraction never reaches zero. The period during which the Universe is mostly neutral is often called *Dark Ages*.

At a much later time ($z \sim 6 - 8$), the Universe will eventually be reionized thanks to the formation of the first massive O-class stars³.

5.3.2 Photon Decoupling

Photons are most strongly coupled to the primordial plasma through their interactions with electrons

$$e^- + \gamma \rightleftharpoons e^- + \gamma$$

³ You can check my Extragalactic Astrophysics Notes if you're interested.

with an interaction rate given, as usual, by $\Gamma = n_e \sigma c$. Here the interaction cross section is that of Thomson scattering $\sigma_T \approx 2 \cdot 10^{-3} \text{ MeV}^{-2}$. Photons and electrons decouple roughly when the interaction rate becomes smaller than the expansion rate

$$\Gamma_\gamma(T_{\text{dec}}) \sim H(T_{\text{dec}}) \quad (191)$$

Writing

$$\begin{aligned} \Gamma_\gamma(T_{\text{dec}}) &= n_b X_e(T_{\text{dec}}) \sigma_T = \frac{2\zeta(3)}{\pi^2} \eta \sigma_T X_e(T_{\text{dec}}) T_{\text{dec}}^3 \\ H(T_{\text{dec}}) &= H_0 \sqrt{\Omega_m} \left(\frac{T_{\text{dec}}}{T_0} \right)^{3/2} \end{aligned}$$

Recall that both recombination and decoupling both occur after matter-radiation equality, hence the Universe is roughly matter dominated.

we get

$$X_e(T_{\text{dec}}) T_{\text{dec}}^{3/2} \sim \frac{\pi^2}{2\zeta(3)} \frac{H_0 \sqrt{\Omega_m}}{\eta \sigma_T T_0^{3/2}} \quad (192)$$

Thanks to Saha's equation we finally find

$$T_{\text{dec}} \sim 0.27 \text{ eV} \quad (193)$$

Notice that although T_{dec} isn't far from T_{rec} , the ionization fraction decreases significantly between recombination and decoupling

$$X_e(T_{\text{rec}}) \approx 0.1 \rightarrow X_e(T_{\text{dec}}) \approx 0.01$$

This shows that a large degree of neutrality is necessary for the universe to become transparent to photon propagation.

The redshift and time of decoupling are, respectively, $z \approx 1090$, and $t \approx 370,000 \text{ yr}$.

5.4 DARK MATTER

Dark matter is a...thorny subject: At the same time we know little to nothing about it, and yet know plenty. We know that it must be abundant, much more abundant than standard baryonic matter, and must not interact with electromagnetic radiation. That, incidentally, also means that we can't see it, hence the name.

So how do we know that it must exist? To put it simply, we have several astrophysical evidences, gravitational in nature, that suggest the presence of this exotic type of matter.

To name a few, you might know that galactic rotation curves would look rather different if DM halos didn't exist: The first discrepancies between the expected and the observed rotation curves were investigated as early as the 1970s [2], [9] bringing the astrophysicists of the time to speculate the existence of something they couldn't see but that had to have a density $\rho \propto r^{-2}$ so that rotation curves could be flat as they looked like.

Another evidence came from structure formation theory. If DM didn't exist, there wouldn't have been enough time for standard baryonic matter to collapse and produce structures much denser than the average background of the Universe like galaxies or clusters.

MOND: Modified Newtonian Dynamics

At the time, not everyone was buying the thing about dark matter.

It felt...convenient, too convenient. So of course they produced another extremely convenient theory, which is that of *Modified Newtonian Dynamics*. Essentially MOND's stans claimed (and apparently some still claim) that Newton's celebrated 2nd law of dynamics $\vec{F} = m\vec{a}$ didn't hold equally for all acceleration scales, but rather had to be modified introducing an acceleration-dependent function $\mu(a/a_0)$, with $a_0 \sim 10^{-10} \text{ m s}^{-2}$.

Newton's second law would then look like

$$\vec{F}_N = m\vec{a} \cdot \begin{cases} 1 & a/a_0 \gg 1 \\ a/a_0 & a/a_0 \ll 1 \end{cases} \quad (194)$$

Applying this to an object of mass m in circular orbit around a point mass M yields

$$m \left(\frac{a^2}{a_0} \right) = \frac{GMm}{r^2}$$

In the deep MOND regime, the true acceleration of a test particle on a circular orbit is still the centripetal acceleration, so

$$\left(\frac{v_c^2}{r} \right)^2 = \frac{GMa_0}{r^2}$$

which is none other than the Baryonic Tully-Fisher relation

$$v_c^4 = GMa_0 \quad (195)$$

This would be great if (a) the BTFR scaled exactly with v^4 (obviously it doesn't), (b) didn't exist the bullet-cluster proof: It proved that during the collision of two clusters of galaxies, the gravitational lensing is centered on the gas-stripped clusters (where the DM would be) rather than on the stripped gas as MOND would predict.

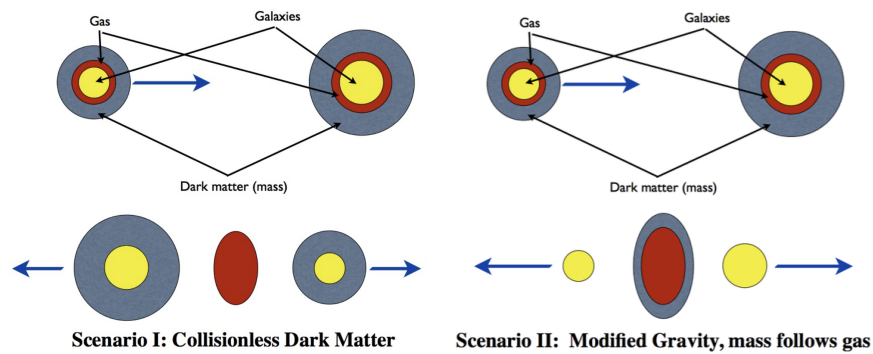


Figure 5: The two different scenarios that were surmised when the bullet cluster was first discovered.

Unfortunately for MOND, the scenario of collisionless DM prevailed, as shown by Fig.6.



Figure 6: The so-called bullet cluster evidence. Three colliding galaxy clusters and one colliding group (at the lower-left), showing the separation between X-rays (pink) and gravitation (blue), indicative of dark matter.

5.4.1 Galaxy Clusters

Galaxy clusters, as the name suggests, are systems comprising of multiple galaxies. They were already object of studies back in the 1930s.

One cool thing about them is that they verify the *virial theorem*

$$2\langle T \rangle_{\text{trasl.}} = - \sum_k \langle \vec{F}_k \cdot \vec{r}_k \rangle_{\text{trasl.}} \quad (196)$$

which under the assumption of a conservative force associated to a central potential $U(r) \propto r^{-n}$ translates into the equation the theorem is most known with

$$2\langle T \rangle_{\text{trasl.}} = -n\langle U \rangle \quad (197)$$

Assuming gravitational potential, the virial theorem allows us to predict the total mass of a cluster by making a simple assumption about its symmetry (spherical, of course) and through measurement of the velocity dispersion of the galaxies within

$$M_{\text{tot}} = \frac{5R\langle v^2 \rangle}{3G} \quad (198)$$

which, for example, for the Coma Cluster predicts a mass $M_{\text{tot}} \approx 2 \cdot 10^{15} M_{\odot}$. For such a cluster, the mass-to-light ratio M/L would be roughly equal to $250 M_{\odot}/L_{\odot}$. Even carrying out the due computations with some more care, you don't manage to bring it below $\sim 10 - 20 M_{\odot}/L_{\odot}$, which is not good since the expected mass-to-light ratio is of order $2 - 3 M_{\odot}/L_{\odot}$.

Moreover, as was ascertained from the aforementioned interaction between clusters, DM is also barely interacting with itself, let alone matter or radiation. One of the few viable ways we can detect its presence and its effects is gravitational lensing.

Research in the cosmological field mainly focuses on two major events: The BBN and the CMB, both of which allows us to measure Ω_m and Ω_b .

Cluster trivia. Did you know that the mass of a cluster is composed by:

- 1% stars;
- 9% Intracluster Medium;
- 90% Dark Matter.

Clearly, if we assume only DM and baryonic matter to contribute to Ω_m , a simple subtraction makes us able to give an estimate to DM's density parameter.

The current values give

$$\Omega_m \approx 0.3 \quad \Omega_b \approx 0.0486 \implies \Omega_{DM} = 0.2589 \quad (199)$$

so most of the matter contribution comes from DM.

What if we wanted to use the values of Ω_b and Ω_{DM} to put constraints on the mass our hypothetical DM particle should have? Would that be of any help? Present estimates constrain DM mass in the range

$$10^{-22} \text{ eV} \lesssim m_{DM} \lesssim m_{PBH} \approx 10^{70} \text{ eV} \approx 10^4 - 10^5 M_\odot \quad (200)$$

corresponding to scales of order

$$\lambda \sim (2 \text{ kpc}) \left(\frac{10^{-22} \text{ eV}}{m} \right) \left(\frac{10 \text{ km s}^{-1}}{v} \right) \quad (201)$$

With only this information at hand, the only candidate within the current Standard Model is the neutrino: It does not emit light, it's barely interacting with other stuff, it's non-baryonic, and it's stable on cosmological scales. However structure-formation theory has long discarded neutrinos as viable candidates for DM: To put it simply, neutrinos would be too "hot" (read: relativistic for far too long after their decoupling), and their free-streaming would smear out density fluctuations on scales of order

$$d_{\min} \approx ct_h \approx 13 \text{ kpc} \left(\frac{m_h c^2}{3 \text{ eV}} \right)^{-2} \quad (202)$$

$$r_{\min} = \frac{d_{\min}}{a(t_h)} \approx 55 \text{ Mpc} \left(\frac{m_h c^2}{3 \text{ eV}} \right)^{-1} \quad (203)$$

where the latter is the scale in comoving units (i.e., the size of the region *today*) below which fluctuations are erased.

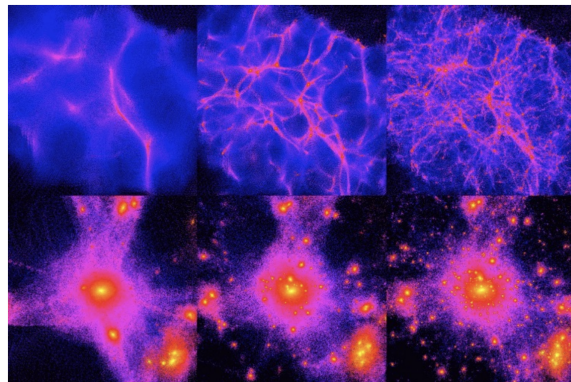


Figure 7: Top row: Simulations of what structure in Hot (left), Warm (middle), and Cold (Right) dark matter Universes would look like at high redshift (early times). Bottom row: same as top row, except now as they would look at the present time ($z = 0$). Credits: ITC University of Zurich.

Even considering the current estimated range for the mass of the neutrino, no mass in that range would allow us to observe *now* structures that have already collapsed and fragmented.

The only possibility for that to happen is that DM must be *cold* (i.e. non-relativistic) at decoupling. Technically speaking we cannot fully exclude the possibility of other candidates for DM like particles yet to be discovered or primordial black holes.

5.4.2 WIMPS

In the last section we've listed quite a few properties we're requiring DM to have. Let's briefly recall them:

1. Negligible light emission;
2. Weakly interacting;
3. Non-baryonic;
4. Cold (non-relativistic at decoupling);
5. Either stable or with $\tau_{1/2} \gg \tau_{\text{Universe}}$.

A possible class of candidates that meets all these requirements is that of the WIMPS⁴ (*Weakly Interacting Massive Particles*). The expected mass for the WIMPS would be in the range $1 \text{ GeV} \lesssim m_{\text{WIMPS}} \lesssim \text{TeV}$.

Thermal Decoupling: Freeze-Out

The interested reader might refer also to [4] and [7] for a more comprehensive and extensive discussion on the subject.

As a matter of fact, the WIMPS decoupling is the non-relativistic version of neutrinos' decoupling. We start by calculating the freeze-out temperature

$$\Gamma \sim H \rightarrow n\sigma v \sim \frac{T_{\text{FO}}^2}{M_{\text{Pl}}} \quad (204)$$

We can define $x_{\text{FO}} = m_{\chi}/T_{\text{FO}}$ (with χ we're referring to WIMPS) so that

$$(m_{\chi} T_{\text{FO}})^{3/2} \exp(m_{\chi}/T_{\text{FO}}) \sigma v \sim \frac{T_{\text{FO}}^2}{M_{\text{Pl}}} \quad (205)$$

which we can promptly rewrite as

$$\boxed{x_{\text{FO}}^{1/2} \exp(-x_{\text{FO}}) \sim \frac{1}{m_{\chi} M_{\text{Pl}} \sigma v} := C} \quad (206)$$

Let's throw in some numbers by setting a benchmark Model: $m_{\chi} \sim 100 \text{ GeV}$ (electroweak scale), $M_{\text{Pl}} \sim 10^{19} \text{ GeV}$, $\sigma \sim 10^{-6} \text{ GeV}^{-2}$, and $v \sim \text{o}(1)$, which all reflect into

$$C = 10^{-15} \quad x_{\text{FO}} \approx 36 \quad (207)$$

⁴ Currently, WIMPS are beginning to pop out in scenarios of beyond-SM physics, such as in supersymmetric theories.

Spanning through the whole WIMPS admitted range of masses bounds $x_{FO} \in [20, 40]$. We can also use the equipartition theorem

$$\frac{3}{2}kT_{FO} \sim \frac{1}{2}mv^2 \rightarrow v \sim \frac{1}{3} \quad (208)$$

WIMPS Miracle

It just remains to relate the freeze-out abundance of dark matter relics to the dark matter density today

$$\Omega_{\chi,0} = \frac{\rho_{\chi,0}}{\rho_c} = \frac{m_\chi n_{\chi,0}}{\rho_c} = \frac{m_\chi n_{\chi,0} T_0^3}{\rho_c T_0^3} \quad (209)$$

Since $n \propto a^{-3}$ and $a \propto T^{-1}$, $n/T^3 \sim \text{const.}$ This we can use to rewrite the expression for $\Omega_{\chi,0}$ as

$$\Omega_{\chi,0} = \frac{m_\chi T_0^3}{\rho_c} \left(\frac{n_{\chi,0}}{T_0^3} \right) = \frac{T_0^3}{\rho_c} x_{FO} \left(\frac{n_{\chi,0}}{T_0^3} \right) \quad (210)$$

but we also have the decoupling condition

$$n_{FO} \sigma v \sim \frac{T_{FO}^2}{M_{Pl}} \quad (211)$$

Putting everything together yields

$$\Omega_{\chi,0} = \left(\frac{T_0^3}{\rho_c M_{Pl}} \right) x_{FO} \frac{1}{\langle \sigma v \rangle} \quad (212)$$

or we can put some numbers in

$$\boxed{\left(\frac{\Omega_{\chi,0} h^2}{0.2} \right) \approx \left(\frac{x_{FO}}{20} \right) \left(\frac{10^{-8} \text{ GeV}^{-2}}{\langle \sigma v \rangle} \right)} \quad (213)$$

This reproduces the observed dark matter density if

$$\sqrt{\langle \sigma v \rangle} \sim 10^{-4} \text{ GeV}^{-1} \sim 0.1 \sqrt{G_F} \quad (214)$$

The fact that a thermal relic with a cross section characteristic of the weak interaction gives the right dark matter abundance is called the WIMP miracle.

Boltzmann Equation

Technically speaking, the formal tool to describe the evolution beyond equilibrium is the Boltzmann equation. Assume we want to study the interaction process reported below with cross section σ

$$1 + 2 \rightleftharpoons 3 + 4 \quad (215)$$

each species with a given numeric density n_i . In the absence of interactions, the number density of a particle species i evolves as

$$\dot{n}_i + 3 \frac{\dot{a}}{a} n_i = 0 \iff \frac{1}{a^3} \frac{d}{dt} (n_i a^3) = 0 \quad (216)$$

This is simply a reflection of the fact that the number of particles in a fixed physical volume is conserved, so that the density dilutes with the expanding volume. To include the effects of interactions we add a collision term to the right-hand side

$$\frac{1}{a^3} \frac{d}{dt}(n_i a^3) = C_i[\{n_j\}] \quad (217)$$

This is the Boltzmann equation. The form of the collision term depends on the specific interactions under consideration. Suppose we are interested in tracking the number density n_1 of species 1. Obviously, the rate of change in the abundance of species 1 is given by the difference between the rates for producing and eliminating the species. The Boltzmann equation simply formalises this statement

$$\frac{1}{a^3} \frac{d}{dt}(n_1 a^3) = -\alpha n_1 n_2 + \beta n_3 n_4 \quad (218)$$

The first term, $-\alpha n_1 n_2$, describes the destruction of particles 1, while that second term, $\beta n_3 n_4$, describes the creation of particles 1. The parameter $\alpha = \langle \sigma v \rangle$ is the *thermally averaged cross section*. The second parameter β can be related to α by noting that the collision term has to vanish in (chemical) equilibrium

$$\beta = \left(\frac{n_1 n_2}{n_3 n_4} \right)_{\text{eq}} \alpha \quad (219)$$

where the densities n_i are the ones at equilibrium. We therefore find

$$\boxed{\frac{1}{a^3} \frac{d}{dt}(n_1 a^3) = -\langle \sigma v \rangle \left[n_1 n_2 - \left(\frac{n_1 n_2}{n_3 n_4} \right)_{\text{eq}} n_3 n_4 \right]} \quad (220)$$

It is instructive to write this in terms of the number of particles in a comoving volume $N_i = n_i a^3$. Since

$$d(\ln a) = \frac{da}{a} \implies \frac{d(\ln N_i)}{d(\ln a)} = \frac{a d(\ln(n_i a^3))}{da} = \frac{1}{H} \frac{1}{n_i a^3} \frac{d}{dt}(n_i a^3) \quad (221)$$

we can rewrite (220) as

$$\frac{d(\ln N_i)}{d(\ln a)} = -\frac{n_2 \langle \sigma v \rangle}{H} \left[1 - \left(\frac{n_1 n_2}{n_3 n_4} \right)_{\text{eq}} \frac{n_3 n_4}{n_1 n_2} \right] = -\frac{\Gamma}{H} \left[1 - \left(\frac{n_1 n_2}{n_3 n_4} \right)_{\text{eq}} \frac{n_3 n_4}{n_1 n_2} \right] \quad (222)$$

The right-hand side of last equation contains a factor describing the interaction efficiency, Γ/H , and a factor characterizing the deviation from equilibrium, the one within parentheses. We can define two regimes:

1. $\Gamma/H \gg 1$: The system is always driven towards its equilibrium configuration. As long as the interaction rates are large, the system quickly relaxes to a steady state where the r.h.s. vanishes and the particles assume their equilibrium abundances;
2. $\Gamma/H \ll 1$: The r.h.s. gets suppressed and the comoving density of particles approaches a constant relic density (*freeze-out*).

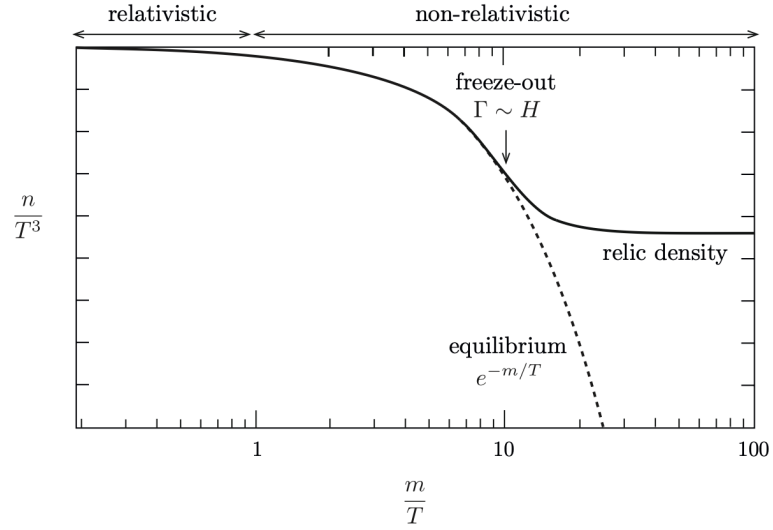


Figure 8: A schematic illustration of particle freeze-out. At high temperatures, $T \gg m$, the particle abundance tracks its equilibrium value. At low temperatures, $T \ll m$, the particles freeze out and maintain a density that is much larger than the Boltzmann-suppressed equilibrium abundance. Credits: [1].

Both scenarios are pictorially represented in Fig.8.

Another possibility is the "hot-decoupling," like that of neutrinos, that produces a hot relic. With reference to Fig.8, you might imagine it as though the curve never drops for a broad range of values for x .

For neutrinos we can define a free-streaming length

$$\lambda_{FS} = \int_{t_{dec}}^{t_{s.f.}} \frac{v(t) dt}{a(t)} \sim 1 \text{ Mpc} \left(\frac{1 \text{ eV}}{m_\nu} \right) \quad (223)$$

which is what allows us to say that if DM were made of hot neutrinos, we wouldn't have structures below the Mpc-scale.

5.5 BIG BANG NUCLEOSYNTHESIS

Coming soon.

In the integral, $t_{s.f.}$ stands for some time associated to structure formation.

Part I

APPENDIX

APPENDIX B: BLACKBODY FUNCTION

Even at an undergraduate level, we're all fairly familiar with *blackbody radiation*. The easiest way to deduce the expression for the energy density of photons in *thermal equilibrium* (STE) inside a cavity is by the means of statistical mechanics.

Remember the Bose-Einstein distribution ($\mu = 0$)

$$n = \frac{1}{\exp(h\nu/kT) - 1}$$

and the phase space density of states (per unit volume)

$$\rho(\nu) d\nu = \frac{4\pi h g \nu^3}{c^3} d\nu$$

from which deducing the expression from internal energy is straightforward. Remembering $g = 2$ is the quantum degeneracy of photons, a simple multiplication of the previous expressions yields

$$U_\nu d\nu = \frac{8\pi h}{c^3} \frac{\nu^3}{\exp(h\nu/kT) - 1} d\nu \quad (224)$$

The energy of a photon is $E_\gamma = h\nu$, meaning the number of photons in the frequency range $\nu \rightarrow \nu + d\nu$ is

$$n_\nu d\nu = \frac{8\pi}{c^3} \frac{\nu^2}{\exp(h\nu/kT) - 1} d\nu \quad (225)$$

which can be integrated over all frequencies, thus obtaining the number density of photons in blackbody radiation

$$n_\gamma = \beta T^3 \quad \beta = \frac{2.4041k^3}{\pi^2 \hbar^3 c^3} \quad (226)$$

Since blackbody radiation is isotropic (it depends only on the absolute temperature T), the definition of mean monochromatic intensity yields

$$B_\nu(T) = \frac{2h\nu^3}{c^2} \frac{1}{\exp(h\nu/kT) - 1} \quad (227)$$

It's important to notice that, in principle, such a fundamental result holds only in *strict thermodynamic equilibrium* (STE), but it's possible to generalize this formulation for less "restrictive" environments.

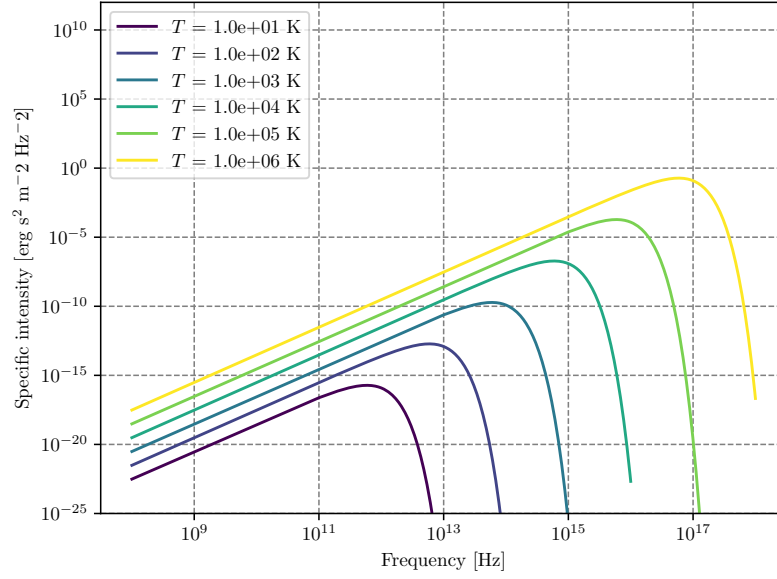


Figure 9: Blackbody frequency spectrum.

An incredible number of important results descends from (227), and it may be worthwhile to cite at least some of them, starting from Stefan-Boltzmann law. We'll use the following result without proving it

$$\int_0^{+\infty} B_\nu(T) d\nu = \frac{2h}{c^2} \frac{\pi^4}{15} \left(\frac{kT}{h} \right)^4$$

Computing the bolometric flux and the bolometric energy density by integrating over all frequencies using what we've just written down, you find the following

$$U(T) = aT^4 \quad F(T) = \sigma_{SB}T^4$$

Clearly the two constants a and σ_{SB} cannot be independent, and are actually related by the integral we've previously calculated. Using for example¹

$$F(T) = \pi \int_0^{+\infty} B_\nu(T) d\nu$$

you can easily find out that the *Stefan-Boltzmann constant* is equal to

$$\sigma_{SB} = \frac{2\pi^5 k^4}{15c^2 h^3}$$

and the relation with a is simply $\sigma_{SB} = ac/4$.

The equation

$$F(T) = \frac{2\pi^5 k^4}{15c^2 h^3} T^4 \tag{228}$$

is what is usually known as the *Stefan-Boltzmann law*.

¹ The emergent flux from an isotropically emitting surface (such as a blackbody) is $\pi \cdot$ brightness which is none other than the specific intensity.

Let us now consider two different regimes for eq.227: $h\nu/kT \ll 1$ and $h\nu/kT \gg 1$. The first yields what is commonly known as the Rayleigh-Jeans Law which is, sadly, pretty much relevant only for radioastronomy.

Since

$$\exp\left(\frac{h\nu}{kT}\right) = 1 + \frac{h\nu}{kT} + o\left(\frac{h\nu}{kT}\right)^2$$

the blackbody radiation assumes the much simpler form of

$$B_\nu^{RJ} = \frac{2\nu^2}{c^2} kT$$

Another important results is achieved in the opposite regime, when the exponential term is rather larger than unity

$$B_\nu^W = \frac{2h\nu^3}{c^2} \exp\left(-\frac{h\nu}{kT}\right)$$

This expression is known as Wien's Law.

Characteristic Temperatures

Starting from the blackbody spectrum we can give various definitions of temperature, that are going to be more and less useful when dealing with stars. The definitions are those of [10].

Brightness Temperature

One way of characterizing brightness (specific intensity) at a certain frequency is to give the temperature of the blackbody having the same brightness at that frequency. That is, for any value I_ν we define $T_b(\nu)$ by the relation

$$I_\nu = B_\nu(T_b)$$

this way of specifying brightness has the advantage of being closely connected with the physical properties of the emitter, and has the simple unit (K).

This procedure is used especially in radio astronomy, where the Rayleigh-Jeans law is usually applicable.

$$T_b = \frac{c^2}{2\nu k} I_\nu \quad h\nu/kT \ll 1 \quad (229)$$

Note that the uniqueness of the definition of brightness temperature relies on the monotonicity property of Planck's law. Also note that, in general, the brightness temperature is a function of ν .

Color Temperature

Often a spectrum is measured to have a shape more or less of blackbody form, but not necessarily of the proper absolute value. For example, by measuring F_ν , from an unresolved source we cannot find I_ν , unless we know the distance to the source and its physical size.

By fitting the data to a blackbody curve without regard to vertical scale, a color temperature T_c , is obtained. Often the “fitting” procedure is nothing more than estimating the peak of the spectrum and applying Wien’s displacement law to find a temperature.

Effective Temperature

The effective temperature of a source T_{eff} is derived from the total amount of flux, integrated over all frequencies, radiated at the source. We obtain T_{eff} by equating the actual flux F to the flux of a blackbody at temperature T_{eff}

$$F = \int I_\nu \cos \theta \, d\nu \, d\Omega := \sigma T_{eff}^4 \quad (230)$$

APPENDIX C: CHRISTOFFEL SYMBOLS

For a symmetric, metric-compatible covariant derivative ∇_μ , the Christoffel symbols are given by

$$\Gamma_{\mu\nu}^\alpha = \frac{1}{2}g^{\lambda\alpha}(\partial_\mu g_{\lambda\nu} + \partial_\nu g_{\mu\lambda} - \partial_\lambda g_{\mu\nu}) \quad (231)$$

For the FLWR metric (35), the Christoffel symbols are given by

$$\begin{aligned} \Gamma_{11}^0 &= \frac{a\dot{a}}{1-kr^2} & \Gamma_{11}^1 &= \frac{kr}{1-kr^2} \\ \Gamma_{22}^0 &= a\dot{a}r^2 & \Gamma_{33}^0 &= a\dot{a}r^2 \sin^2 \theta \\ \Gamma_{0j}^i &= \frac{\dot{a}}{a}\delta_j^i = H\delta_j^i & \Gamma_{01}^1 &= \frac{\dot{a}}{a} = H \\ \Gamma_{22}^1 &= -r(1-kr^2) & \Gamma_{33}^1 &= -r(1-kr^2) \sin^2 \theta \\ \Gamma_{12}^2 &= \Gamma_{13}^3 = \frac{1}{r} & \Gamma_{33}^2 &= -\sin \theta \cos \theta \\ \Gamma_{23}^3 &= \cot \theta & \Gamma_{00}^i &= 0 \\ \Gamma_{00}^0 &= 0 & \Gamma_{i0}^0 &= 0 \end{aligned}$$

or related to this by symmetry. The non-zero components of the Ricci tensor are

$$\begin{aligned} R_{00} &= -3\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} \\ R_{11} &= \frac{a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2k}{1-kr^2} \\ R_{22} &= r^2(a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2k) \\ R_{33} &= r^2(a\ddot{a} + 2\dot{a}^2 + 2k) \sin^2 \theta \end{aligned}$$

and the Ricci scalar is then

$$R = 6 \left[\frac{\ddot{a}}{a} \left(\frac{\dot{a}}{a} \right)^2 + \frac{k}{a^2} \right]$$

APPENDIX D: WHERE THE D STANDS FOR DEMONSTRATION

The FLRW Killing Tensor

In Chapter 4 we've defined at a certain point a Killing tensor (49) but I never showed that it actually satisfies Killing's equation. Our goal is to show that the tensor

$$K_{\mu\nu} = a^2(g_{\mu\nu} + u_\mu u_\nu) \quad (232)$$

satisfies $\nabla_{(\sigma} K_{\mu\nu)} = 0$.

Let's start from observing that $K_{\mu\nu}$ is a spatial projector

$$u^\nu K_{\mu\nu} = a^2(u^\nu g_{\mu\nu} + u_\mu u_\nu u^\nu) = 0 \quad (233)$$

since $u_\nu u^\nu = -1$. This means that we can define $h_{\mu\nu} = g_{\mu\nu} + u_\mu u_\nu$ so that $K_{\mu\nu} = a^2 h_{\mu\nu}$. Note that $h_{\mu\nu}$ coincides with the spatial sections of the FLRW metric.

Before calculating the covariant derivative of the alleged Killing tensor, let's first check

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla_\mu u_\nu &= \partial_\mu u_\nu - \Gamma_{\mu\nu}^\lambda u_\lambda \\ &= +\Gamma_{\mu\nu}^0 = \frac{1}{2} g^{00} \partial_0 g_{\mu\nu} \\ &= -\frac{1}{2} \partial_0 (h_{\mu\nu} - u_\mu u_\nu) \\ &= -\frac{1}{2} \partial_0 h_{\mu\nu} = -\frac{1}{2} \partial_0 (a^2 \tilde{h}_{\mu\nu}) = -a\dot{a} \tilde{h}_{\mu\nu} = -H h_{\mu\nu} \end{aligned}$$

We can now expand the covariant derivative of $K_{\mu\nu}$

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla_\lambda K_{\mu\nu} &= h_{\mu\nu} \nabla_\lambda a^2 + a^2 \nabla_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} \\ &= 2a\dot{a} u_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} + a^2 \nabla_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} \\ &= 2a\dot{a} u_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} + a^2 (u_\mu \nabla_\lambda u_\nu + u_\nu \nabla_\lambda u_\mu) \end{aligned}$$

where we can now substitute $\nabla_\mu u_\nu = -H h_{\mu\nu}$ to obtain

$$\begin{aligned} \nabla_\lambda K_{\mu\nu} &= 2a\dot{a} u_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} - a\dot{a} (u_\mu h_{\nu\lambda} + u_\nu h_{\mu\lambda}) \\ &= a\dot{a} [(u_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} - u_\mu h_{\lambda\nu}) + (u_\lambda h_{\mu\nu} - u_\nu h_{\lambda\mu})] \\ &= 2a\dot{a} [u_{[\lambda} h_{\mu]\nu} + u_{[\lambda} h_{\nu]\mu}] \end{aligned}$$

At this point, we can easily see that the symmetrization $\nabla_{(\sigma} K_{\mu\nu)}$ of the previous expression yields zero, thus proving that $K_{\mu\nu}$ is indeed a Killing tensor.

ABOUT ME

Hi there, I'm Giacomo, sometimes known as Cael by a very small niche of people, the author of the notes you just finished reading.

I'm a Bachelor-graduate student at the University of Pisa now in the process of undertaking a major (Master degree) in Astronomy and Astrophysics at the same university. In my (meager) free time I'm an avid reader, gamer, anime-enthusiast as well as an independent author in the very process of publishing his first novel.

For those of you that may be interested I'll leave both the link to the novel's page as well to my instagram profile in the QRcodes right below.

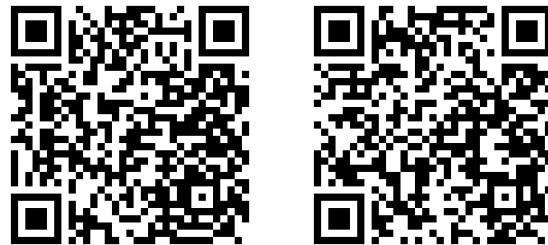


Figure 10: On the left is the link to my instagram profile, on the right the one to my novel's page (Python really has a library for anything, huh?).

Come say hi if you fancy action-fantasy stories with magic, swords, some comedy to garnish and a lot of other stuff :)

At last but not the least, I want to thank all my colleagues and fellow students that helped (and hopefully will help me again) during the drafting of this text, pointing out errors and occasions for further expansion.

If you'd like your names to be included and take your fair share of credits, feel free to contact me and I'll add your name right away in the few lines that are left of this page.

I hope my understading of the complex interplayings going on in our Universe has managed to facilitate your own understading.

If not, well... oopsie.

See you, space cowboys...

Giacomo

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- [1] Daniel Baumann. *Cosmology*. Cambridge University Press, 2022.
- [2] A. Bosma. *The distribution and kinematics of neutral hydrogen in spiral galaxies of various morphological types*. PhD thesis, University of Groningen, Netherlands, March 1978.
- [3] Sean M. Carroll. *Spacetime and Geometry: An Introduction to General Relativity*. Cambridge University Press, 2019.
- [4] Marco Cirelli, Alessandro Strumia, and Jure Zupan. Dark matter, 2025.
- [5] Albert Einstein. Kosmologische Betrachtungen zur allgemeinen Relativitätstheorie. *Sitzungsberichte der Königlich Preussischen Akademie der Wissenschaften*, pages 142–152, January 1917.
- [6] Edwin. Hubble. No. 324. Extra-galactic nebulae. *Contributions from the Mount Wilson Observatory / Carnegie Institution of Washington*, 324:1–49, January 1926.
- [7] Stefano Profumo. Tasi 2012 lectures on astrophysical probes of dark matter, 2013.
- [8] Adam G. Riess, Wenlong Yuan, Lucas M. Macri, Dan Scolnic, Dillon Brout, Stefano Casertano, David O. Jones, Yukei Murakami, Gagandeep S. Anand, Louise Breuval, Thomas G. Brink, Alexei V. Filippenko, Samantha Hoffmann, Saurabh W. Jha, W. D’arcy Kenworthy, John Mackenty, Benjamin E. Stahl, and WeiKang Zheng. A comprehensive measurement of the local value of the hubble constant with $1 \text{ km s}^{-1} \text{ Mpc}^{-1}$ uncertainty from the hubble space telescope and the shoes team. *The Astrophysical Journal Letters*, 934(1), July 2022.
- [9] V. C. Rubin, W. K. Ford, Jr., and N. Thonnard. Extended rotation curves of high-luminosity spiral galaxies. IV. Systematic dynamical properties, Sa -> Sc. *Astrophysical Journal Letters*, 225:L107–L111, November 1978.
- [10] George B. Rybicki and Alan P. Lightman. *Radiative Processes in Astrophysics*. 1986.